

RS 2,500 PROMISE, NOW IN MOTION **P3**



PM TO MOTIVATE YOUTH TO TAKE UP SPORTS, SHAPE INDIA'S FUTURE **P5**

THE TRUE COUNTRY MUSIC QUEEN **P10**



DISQUALIFICATION PROCEEDINGS
Lok Sabha Speaker issues notices to 20 rebel TMC MPs
OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kolkata, August 26
Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla has begun proceedings on disqualification petitions against 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs, issuing notices to them and giving seven days to respond, shortly after the Supreme Court took up the issue of the delay in deciding the petitions.
The Speaker's move was conveyed to a three-judge bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant during the hearing of TMC general secretary and Lok Sabha leader Abhishek Banerjee's plea seeking a time-bound decision on the disqualification proceedings.
The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya **CONTINUED ON P4**

Floods ravage Nepal

NEARLY 160 DEAD, 750 MISSING



A torrent of muddy water flows through the Trishuli River following a flash flood triggered by the Lende river, and merges into the Bhote Koshi river **PTI**

95 bodies recovered; 19 bridges washed away; Eight operational hydropower projects damaged

MPOST BUREAU
Kathmandu, August 26

Nearly 160 people were killed and more than 750 remained missing after a massive flash flood originating in Tibet swept through central Nepal on Wednesday, destroying bridges, roads and hydro-power facilities and leaving a trail of destruction across several districts. Nepalese officials said 95 bodies had been recovered and around 500 people were still missing on the Nepal side, while Chinese state media reported three deaths and 265 missing on the Chinese side of the border. At least 133 Indian nationals and 37 non-resident Indians were among those missing in Nepal.
The disaster began in the Bhote Koshi river system along the Nepal-Tibet border and rapidly moved downstream, affecting Rasuwa and Dhading before spreading into Nuwakot, Chitwan, Gorkha, Tanahun and Nawalparasi East. The

HOW THE FLASH FLOOD UNFOLDED

- » **8:37 AM | EARTHQUAKE HITS TIBET**
A TREMOR STRUCK THE TIBET REGION, ACCORDING TO NEPAL'S FOREIGN MINISTER SHISIR KHANAL.
- » **+3 MINUTES | FLOODS REPORTED**
Flash flooding was reported just three minutes later, raising the possibility of a quake-triggered glacial outburst.
- » **ROCKSLIDE | WATER BREAKS THROUGH**
A rockslide and swelling of the Lhunde River along the Nepal-Tibet border sent a huge volume of water into the Bhote Koshi River at Timure in Rasuwa.
- » **DOWNSTREAM | TORRENT RACES THROUGH NEPAL**
The flood entered the Trishuli River and tore through Rasuwa and Dhading before spreading to Nuwakot, Chitwan, Gorkha, Tanahun and Nawalparasi East, washing away bridges, roads and buildings.

CLOSER LOOK

- » 95 bodies recovered
- » 133 Indians, 37 NRIs among those missing
- » 50+ missing Indians were Kailash pilgrims
- » Five under-construction projects also damaged
- » 19 motorable bridges washed away
- » 42-km road to Rasuwagadhi destroyed
- » 354 MW generation capacity hit
- » Around 100 people rescued so far
- » 30 rescued victims treated in Kathmandu

» **NEPAL ARMY DEPLOYS 12 HELICOPTERS** » **80 SECURITY PERSONNEL REMAIN MISSING** » **CHINA SENDS 145 PERSONNEL FOR RESCUE**



affected areas lie roughly 70 km to nearly 200 km from Kathmandu. Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal told the House of Representatives that an **CONTINUED ON P4**



A woman looks on as the floodwater flows in spate across a residential area, in Nepal **PTI**

Bihar, UP on high alert; Shah speaks to CMs
NARESH BISWANI
Lucknow/Patna, August 26
Bihar and Uttar Pradesh were placed on high alert on Wednesday after flash floods in neighbouring Nepal caused widespread destruction and raised the possibility of a rise in water levels in the Gandak river system in India. Union Home Minister Amit Shah spoke to Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath as the Centre coordinated with the two states, while the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), local administrations and rescue teams were put on standby in areas likely to be affected.
The Central Water Commission (CWC) said there had been a sudden rise in the **CONTINUED ON P4**

PM MODI SPEAKS TO BALENDRA SHAH

India sends relief, rescue support



NDRF teams load relief material **ANI**

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE
New Delhi, August 26

India on Wednesday sent 10 tonnes of humanitarian and medical supplies to flood-hit Nepal as rescue operations intensified after a sudden flash flood along the Nepal-Tibet border killed at least 95 people and left hundreds missing, including more than 100 Indians. Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to Nepalese Prime Minister Balendra Shah and offered all possible humanitarian assistance, while Indian missions in Kathmandu and Beijing coordinated with Nepalese and Chinese authorities to help stranded Indian nationals. The Indian Air Force has also planned further air operations, including the deployment of C-17 and C-130 aircraft with additional relief supplies and helicopters for search, rescue and evacuation.
Modi said after his conversation with Shah that the people of India stood in solidarity with Nepal during the crisis. "India is ready to provide all possible humanitarian assistance to Nepal. Our teams are coordinating closely on rescue and relief efforts," he said in a post on X.
The first consignment, comprising 10 tonnes of humanitarian assistance and disaster relief material and essential medicines, was sent to Kathmandu on an IAF C-130J aircraft. The aircraft departed from Hindon airbase near Delhi at around 8:35 pm on Wednesday. The sup-

KEY POINTS

- » India sends 10 tonnes of relief supplies to flood-hit Nepal
- » India's teams coordinate with Nepal on rescue and relief efforts
- » IAF C-130J aircraft carries first relief consignment to Kathmandu
- » Relief supplies include shelters, blankets, hygiene kits, lamps and medicines
- » C-17 and C-130 aircraft will carry additional relief supplies

plies include temporary shelters, blankets, hygiene kits, solar lamps and medicines for people affected by the floods.
External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said India had dispatched the supplies to support Nepal's flood response. "Our thoughts are with the bereaved families and all those affected. In face of this challenge, India stands with Nepal and its people," he said.
The IAF said additional C-17 and C-130 aircraft would carry more relief material, while helicopters had been earmarked for rescue and evacuation operations. Another military transport aircraft is expected to carry supplies to Kathmandu on Thursday morning.
The flash floods struck central Nepal after water surged through the Bhote Koshi river at around 9 am local time, with the floodwaters coming from the Tibet side. Rasuwa and Dhading districts were affected, **CONTINUED ON P4**

Briefs
Delhi's H1N1 tally rises to 2,446
NEW DELHI: Delhi reported 138 new H1N1 cases in the past 24 hours, taking the year's total to 2,446, while Influenza-A cases reached 3,177, the government said on Wednesday.
Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh reviewed hospital preparedness and directed facilities to maintain adequate isolation beds, testing facilities, medicines and emergency staff. **SEE P3**
Centre says onion supply sufficient
NEW DELHI: The Centre on Wednesday said onion supplies were sufficient to meet demand during the festive season and announced the release of buffer stocks to contain a recent rise in retail prices.
The Department of Consumer Affairs said onion prices usually increase during festivals because of higher demand and supply-chain factors. It said the government was monitoring prices and availability and would take further steps if necessary. **CONTINUED ON P4**
Haryanvi singer Balyan shot dead
MUZAFFARNAGAR: Youtuber and Haryanvi singer Ankit Balyan was shot dead by unidentified assailants outside a gym in Shamli district on Wednesday evening, police said. The incident took place in the Kotwali police station area as Balyan was leaving the gym. **CONTINUED ON P4**

India, China reach 8-point consensus on border talks

Beijing, August 26

India and China agreed on an eight-point consensus to advance boundary negotiations and improve border management during the 25th round of Special Representatives' talks between National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing.
The two sides agreed to pursue an "Early and Substantial Harvest" on boundary delimitation and border management, with expert groups first working on their terms of reference. They also decided to address ground situations promptly through existing diplomatic and military channels and

improve understanding of the Line of Actual Control.
Two additional meeting points for senior military commanders and two new border military hotline channels in the eastern and middle sectors were agreed.
The countries will meet in September to discuss trans-border rivers, including hydrological data sharing. They also welcomed the reopening of three border trading points and increased Kailash-Manasarovar pilgrimage batches.
Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to peace and tranquillity along the border and agreed to hold the next SR talks in India in 2027. **SEE P4**

HATHRAS CASE

High Court directs UP to relocate victim's family to Noida or Ghaziabad

MPOST BUREAU
Lucknow, August 25

The Allahabad High Court has directed the Uttar Pradesh government to rehabilitate and relocate the family of the Hathras gang-rape victim to either Ghaziabad or Noida within three months, expressing displeasure over the state's failure to comply with its earlier directions.
A bench of Justices Rajan Roy and Jaspreet Singh also directed the government to provide employment to one member of the family after the rehabilitation is completed, as required under the court's July 26, 2022 order. The bench quashed the state government's February 22, 2025 decision, under which the family had been offered a choice between Kasganj, Etah and Aligarh. **CONTINUED ON P4**

'UP tops pendency list across fast-track courts; Delhi has 7,385 pending cases'

India had 17.54 lakh cases pending before Fast Track Courts by June 30

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 26

Uttar Pradesh accounts for nearly 78 per cent of all cases pending before Fast Track Courts (FTCs) in the country, with more than 13.74 lakh cases awaiting disposal across 373 functional courts, according to data obtained under the Right to Information (RTI) Act.
The figures, shared by the Department of Justice in a reply dated August 10 to a query filed by Noida-based social activist Amit Gupta, show that 17.54 lakh cases were pending before FTCs across India as of June 30, 2026. A total of 884 such courts were functional



in 21 states and Union Territories at the time.
The Department said FTCs are established by states and UTs in consultation with their respective high courts to ensure speedy trials in specified categories of cases. It also said that no central assistance is being provided to states for setting up these courts.
Maharashtra had the second-highest pendency,

KEY POINTS

- » Over 13.74 lakh cases are pending across 373 FTCs in Uttar Pradesh
- » A total of 884 Fast Track Courts were functional across 21 states and UTs
- » Maharashtra has the second-highest pendency, with 1,35,340 cases
- » West Bengal has 93,245 pending cases
- » Tamil Nadu has 89,703 pending cases
- » Assam has 17,145 pending cases

» **DELHI HAS 7,385 PENDING CASES**

with 1,35,340 cases across 117 FTCs, followed by West Bengal with 93,245 cases and Tamil Nadu with 89,703. Assam had 17,145 pending cases, while Delhi had 7,385 cases across 26 functional FTCs.
Sikkim recorded the lowest pendency among states with functional FTCs, with 18 cases across two courts. It was followed by Manipur, with 131 cases across six courts, and Punjab, with 161 cases across seven courts.
The RTI response also shows that 15 of the 36 states and UTs covered in the data had no functional FTCs. These include Bihar, Karnataka, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, **CONTINUED ON P4**

NOIDA: BODY FOUND FIVE DAYS LATER

13-yr-old boy killed by three minors over money dispute

‘Suspects called him to a park on the pretext of a birthday party’

DIPIKA KIROLA
Noida, August 26

A 13-year-old boy was allegedly killed by three minor acquaintances after they took him to a park on the pretext of a birthday party, with police suspecting a dispute over money led to the murder.

The victim, Ayush Shukla, a Class 7 student at Kendriya Vidyalaya in Sector 24, lived with his mother and two sisters in a rented house in Sector 20. His father, Pankaj, is unwell and is currently in Lucknow for treatment.

According to the family, Ayush left home around 4pm on August 16 after telling his mother and sister that he was going to a friend’s birthday party. He was accompanied by two classmates from Chaura village in Sector 22. When he failed to return that night, his mother, Yogmaya, began searching for him.

The family approached police on August 18, but Yogmaya alleged that she had to visit several police posts and stations while trying to trace her son.

Five days after Ayush went missing, police recov-



Eight-yr-old found dead in Rohini lake

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

An eight-year-old boy was found dead under suspicious circumstances in a lake in Delhi’s Aman Vihar area, police sources said Wednesday.

The boy had reportedly gone missing on Tuesday night and a search for him was on.

A police team reached the spot along with a forensic team after his body was found, the source said. The family has raised suspicion of foul play, claiming that there were injury marks on the boy’s head.

The boy was the only brother of four sisters, the

source said.

Speaking to reporters, Ramnath Soni said his son, a class 2 student, was picked up by someone last night on a motorcycle.

“He had been missing since around 10 pm last night. We got to know later that two boys picked him up on a bike. We alerted the police. We found his body around 2 pm in a lake. His head was badly injured. I don’t know the boys who picked him up but they are from the neighbourhood,” he said.

The body has been sent for a postmortem to determine the exact cause of death, he said.

ered the decomposed body of an unidentified boy from a forested area in Sector

54 on the night of August 21. The body was sent for postmortem.

Truck, DTC bus collide in Delhi Cantt, 3 injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

A dump truck collided with a DTC bus in the Delhi Cantonment area on Wednesday morning, leaving three persons injured, police said.

The accident took place near Thiraiya traffic light after crossing the Delhi Cantt flyover towards Dhaula Kuan. Three persons travelling in the truck were injured and the bus driver suffered a fracture in his leg, they said.

A PCR call regarding the incident was received at Delhi Cantt police station at 8:23 am, following which police teams reached the spot and the injured persons were shifted to Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital, a senior police officer said.

The police said the dump truck was being driven by 26-year-old Pritam, who hailed from Uttar Pradesh. He was travelling with Sanoj (28) and Roshan (18), both from Bihar.

The trio were workers engaged with the Delhi Cantonment Board and were carrying out their routine duty when the accident occurred, the officer said.

Three people sustained minor injuries, while the DTC driver suffered a leg fracture. All passengers were safe; police are checking CCTV footage and MLC reports.

Sukesh Chandrasekhar convicted for posing as SC judge to seek bail

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

A Delhi court has convicted alleged conman Sukesh Chandrasekhar for impersonating a sitting Supreme Court judge to influence a special judge for bail in a corruption case in 2017, describing the act as a “direct affront” to the independence and sanctity of the judicial process.

Chief Judicial Magistrate Harshita Mishra held Chandrasekhar guilty of offences under IPC Sections 170 (personating a public servant), 189 (threat of injury to a public servant) and 507 (criminal intimidation by an anonymous communication).

The court will hear him on the quantum of sentence on August 27.

In an order dated August 20, the court said, “The present case shall for posterity remain a reminder that the majesty of law does not reside in the voice of an individual, however authoritative it may sound over a telephone, but in the integrity of the judicial process itself.”

The case arose from a phone call made on April 28, 2017, when Chandrasekhar was in police custody in connection with the corruption case.

According to the prosecution, he obtained access to the mobile phone of police constable Manjeet and used it to contact the official landline and mobile phone of Poonam Chaudhary, then special judge dealing with Prevention of



“PROSECUTION HAD ESTABLISHED BEYOND REASONABLE DOUBT THAT CHANDRASEKHAR DELIBERATELY ASSUMED THE IDENTITY OF A SC JUDGE

Corruption Act cases.

The court said Chandrasekhar first impersonated the private secretary of a then sitting Supreme Court judge and later the judge himself. He allegedly sought to persuade Chaudhary to grant bail to him at the earliest and threatened her with adverse professional consequences if she did not comply.

“A courtroom may be entered through its doors, but justice cannot be entered through the backdoor of impersonation, intimidation or manufactured authority. The accused attempted precisely such a backdoor entry into the judicial process. The evidence has closed that door,” the court said.

The judge said the case was qualitatively different from an ordinary cheating or impersonation matter as the alleged conduct sought to undermine judicial independence by using the authority of the country’s highest court to influence another judicial officer.

“The court also finds it necessary to record that the conduct of the accused constitutes a direct affront

to the independence and sanctity of the judicial process. Courts decide cases on the basis of law and evidence, not on the basis of telephone calls purporting to emanate from persons occupying positions of authority,” the judge said.

The court said the prosecution had established beyond reasonable doubt that Chandrasekhar deliberately assumed the identity of a Supreme Court judge to interfere with the administration of justice.

“The accused sought to use that borrowed authority not for any legitimate purpose, but to procure a judicial outcome favourable to himself. The brazenness of the attempt cannot dilute the offence; rather, it demonstrates the deliberateness with which the criminal design was executed,” the judge said.

The court held that impersonation was central to Chandrasekhar’s attempt to influence the judge, attracting IPC Sections 189 and 507. It called the conduct a direct affront to judicial process and directed police to re-examine constable Manjeet’s role.

Abetment case in IIT student death

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, August 26

Delhi Police has registered a case of abetment to suicide in connection with the death of a 31-year-old M.Sc Physics student of IIT Delhi, who allegedly jumped from the sixth floor of the institute’s Lecture Hall Complex on August 22.

Police said the student entered the campus around 8am after showing his identity card, went to the complex and allegedly jumped from the sixth floor. He was taken to the campus hospital, where he was declared dead.

A PCR call was received at Kishangarh police station around 8.30am.

No suicide note was found. Police seized his phone and are collecting his counselling records and other documents.

The student’s mother alleged that IIT Delhi’s refusal to grant him hostel accommodation worsened his mental trauma and blamed the

Dean and institute authorities for his death. The family has sought Rs 1 crore compensation.

IIT Delhi has ordered an internal probe and offered condolences.

Ex-councillor Tahir Hussain moves HC against life term for murder of IB officer

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

Former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain has approached the Delhi High Court against his conviction and life sentence for the murder of Intelligence Bureau (IB) staffer Ankit Sharma during the February 2020 riots, saying the investigation was aimed at implicating him to satisfy public anger.

The appeal, which was filed on Monday, is likely to come up for hearing next week.

“The investigation against the appellant has

HUSSAIN SOUGHT SETTING ASIDE OF COURT’S JUL 13 CONVICTION ORDER, JUL 31 SENTENCING

been tainted since the very beginning, aimed at implicating him in order to satisfy public anger. The FIR is ante-dated and ante-timed, no material investigation was carried out until March 6, 2020, that is, till the appellant was arrested in another case,” Hussain contended in his appeal.

He further alleged that the witnesses have been planted in the case and statements of genuine eye-witnesses have been

manipulated and that the actual perpetrators have not been brought to book.

Hussain sought setting aside of the trial court’s July 13 conviction order and July 31 sentencing order, contending that the trial court has believed the statements of completely unreliable witnesses and relied upon those who did not witness the incident and completely ignored the tainted investigation including fabrication of

the complaint on which the FIR was based.

According to the prosecution, on February 26, 2020, complainant Ravinder Kumar informed the Dayalpur police station officials that his son Ankit Sharma, who was posted in the Intelligence Bureau, was missing since February 25, 2020.

A trial court sentenced Hussain and four co-conspirators to life imprisonment for IB officer Sharma’s murder during the 2020 Delhi riots, rejecting the death penalty plea as the case did not qualify as “rarest of rare”.

SAMPLES TAKEN FROM HOTELS; ACTION TO FOLLOW REPORTS

FSSAI notice to 5-star hotels JW Marriott, Andaz over hygiene issues, cockroaches...

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Faridabad, August 26

A speeding 10-wheeler truck dragged two traffic policemen for over 50 metres after knocking their motorcycle down in Faridabad’s Parvatiya Colony on Wednesday, killing both, police said.

The deceased were identified as Naveen, 24, from Bhiwani, and Abhishek, 26, from Tosham. Both were posted with the traffic police and attached to Parvatiya Colony police chowki.

A truck hit the constables’ motorcycle while they were patrolling Sohna Road, dragging them for over 50 metres. Both died. The driver fled, abandoning the vehicle; police impounded it, registered an FIR and launched a search.

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

Food regulator FSSAI on Wednesday said it has issued notices to five-star hotels JW Marriott and Andaz at Aerocity here for serious violations of laws related to hygiene, including presence of cockroaches near freezers.

In a social media post, the regulator informed that it has issued a notice to JW Marriott hotel, which is a unit of Aria Hotels and Consultancy Services Pvt Ltd. The notice has been issued “over serious food safety violations and non-compliance with FSSAI requirements.”

In another post, Food



Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) informed that it has issued notice to Juniper Hotels Pvt Ltd (Andaz, Aerocity, Delhi) following inspections that “uncovered serious food safety violations”.

The regulator has collected samples from both the hotels and further action would be taken

based on lab reports. During the inspection, FSSAI officials found serious deficiencies related to hygiene and sanitation.

In the case of JW Marriott, the officials observed inadequate pest control, presence of cockroaches and fruit flies, and poor maintenance of food premises.

“OFFICIALS OBSERVED INADEQUATE PEST CONTROL, PRESENCE OF COCKROACHES AND FRUIT FLIES, AND POOR MAINTENANCE OF FOOD PREMISES

In the case of Andaz hotel, the FSSAI inspection revealed active cockroaches near freezers, houseflies, mosquitoes in the grinding room, spider webs, and the discovery of a ‘gutka’ packet inside the bottling plant area.

Comments from both the hotels could not be immediately obtained.

During the inspection at JW Marriott, FSSAI officials found “serious hygiene and sanitation deficiencies, including unclean utensils and food-contact surfaces, visible particulate matter in drinking water, inadequate pest control, cockroaches and fruit flies, and poor maintenance of food premises.”

The regulator found spoiled/fungal-affected food in the hotel. It also observed improper food storage and cross-contamination risks. FSSAI found serious food safety violations at both hotels, including expired food, pest infestations, poor sanitation, improper storage and labelling deficiencies.

Man killed in road crash in Ghazipur

New Delhi, August 26

A 24-year-old man died after his motorcycle was allegedly hit from behind by an unidentified vehicle on NH-9 near Khichripur Flyover in Delhi’s Ghazipur area, police said on Wednesday.

The deceased, identified as Nitin, was returning home from Ghaziabad when the accident took place around 11.45 pm on Tuesday.

Police said he was trav-

elling towards his home in Delhi when the unidentified vehicle allegedly hit his motorcycle.

A PCR call about the accident was received around midnight. Nitin was taken to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital, where he was declared dead. Police registered a case, are scanning CCTV footage to trace the unidentified vehicle, and reiterated that motorcycles are prohibited on the NH-9 stretch.

MP05T

HOSPITALS TOLD TO STRENGTHEN PREPAREDNESS
H1N1 hits 2,446 in Capital

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, August 26

With 138 new H1N1 cases reported in Delhi in the past 24 hours, Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh on Wednesday held a virtual review meeting with medical heads of Delhi government hospitals to assess preparedness for seasonal influenza and other respiratory illnesses.

The latest cases have taken Delhi's cumulative H1N1 count to 2,446 in 2026, while the total number of Influenza-A cases has reached 3,177. The review focused on emergency services, isolation capacity, testing facilities, medicines and round-the-clock medical support.

Hospitals were directed to maintain at least five isolation beds, while larger facilities have been asked to keep 10 or more beds available for influenza and vector-borne disease cases. The minister also instructed hospitals to maintain shift-wise duty rosters and ensure doctors and medical staff remain available round the clock.

Special attention was directed towards children and elderly patients, with hospitals asked to ensure their timely assessment and appropriate treatment.

The Health Department also instructed hospitals to establish or strengthen dedicated Flu Corners in emergency departments, with



Senior Residents assigned to emergency duties. Suspected patients are to be assessed promptly and swab samples sent for testing wherever clinically required. Hospitals were also asked to maintain adequate stocks of Viral Transport Medium (VTM) and other testing supplies.

Medicine availability was reviewed during the meeting, with hospital administrations directed to regularly report stock levels and undertake local procurement wherever necessary to avoid interruptions in treatment. Speaking after the meeting, Singh said the review was aimed at ensuring hospitals remain prepared without causing unnecessary concern among residents. "This was not merely a meeting to issue instructions, but a comprehensive review of the preparedness of our hospitals. Our doctors and medical teams are working very hard and doing an excellent job," he said.

The minister added that

the availability of beds, testing facilities, medicines and emergency services had been reviewed to ensure continuity of patient care.

"There is no need for panic. Most of the patients who have come to hospitals so far have presented with mild fever and other common symptoms and have recovered within a day or two. Delhi Government hospitals are fully prepared, and our health system is continuously monitoring the situation," Singh said.

He urged residents to remain vigilant and follow respiratory hygiene, hand hygiene and cough etiquette, while avoiding crowded places when symptomatic. People experiencing influenza-like symptoms, particularly those in vulnerable groups, were advised to seek medical attention promptly and avoid self-medication.

The Health Department said influenza trends and hospital preparedness would continue to be monitored closely.

Rs 2,500 promise, now in motion
4,190 women get sanction letters under DELHI LAKSHMI YOJANA

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, August 26

Delhi Lakshmi Yojna formally launched in Delhi on Wednesday, with sanction letters issued to 4,190 eligible women and the Rs 2,500 monthly assistance set to be transferred directly to beneficiaries' bank accounts from September 1. The scheme was formally launched by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at Talkatora Stadium in the presence of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra.

During the launch ceremony, sanction letters were symbolically handed over to 65 selected beneficiaries, while the government said 4,190 women had been issued sanction letters after completing the prescribed eligibility and verification process. The scheme provides Rs 2,500 per month to eligible women aged between 21 and 60 through Direct Benefit Transfer.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta said the government's commitment to provide monthly assistance to women was now becoming a reality. "The scheme is not limited to providing financial assistance, it is also a means of giving women in Delhi financial security, confidence and the ability to make their



AID TO FLOW FROM SEPT 1

- » During the launch ceremony, sanction letters were symbolically handed over to 65 selected beneficiaries, while the government said 4,190 women had been issued sanction letters after completing the prescribed eligibility and verification process
- » The scheme provides Rs 2,500 per month to eligible women aged between 21 and 60 through DBT
- » According to her, Rs 1,000 would be made available through a digital wallet for spending, while Rs 1,500 would be deposited through an FD/RD to encourage savings

own decisions," she said.

The Chief Minister said registrations for the scheme began on August 1 and more than 9.22 lakh women had registered so far. She said the government was working to ensure that eligible beneficiaries received assistance through a transpar-

ent and organised process.

Gupta also said the Rs 2,500 assistance would address both immediate needs and future savings. According to her, Rs 1,000 would be made available through a digital wallet for spending, while Rs 1,500 would be depos-

ited through an FD/RD to encourage savings.

Describing the launch in the context of the festive season, Gupta called the scheme "Teej ka Sindhara" and "Rakhi ki Sau-gaat" from Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Delhi's women.

Briefs

PWD to fix 3 S
Delhi flyovers

NEW DELHI: The Public Works Department (PWD) is planning to undertake repair and maintenance work on stretches of three major South Delhi flyovers, including Nehru Nagar, the AIIMS loops and Barapullah Phase 1, officials said on Wednesday. Located on the Outer Ring Road, the Nehru Nagar flyover connects key routes in Delhi, including Mathura Road, Ashram Chowk and the AIIMS roundabout.

Mayor meets
L-G Sandhu

NEW DELHI: Mayor of Delhi Praveesh Sahib Singh on Wednesday met Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and discussed issues related to the city's development, civic amenities and public welfare, officials said.

131 kg expired
food destroyed

NEW DELHI: Food safety teams in Delhi collected 37 samples of milk products and sweets, and destroyed around 131 kg of expired food items as it stepped up inspections of sweet shops, manufacturing units and vegetable markets ahead of the festive season, officials said on Wednesday.

CAQM steps
up Gzb checks

NEW DELHI: CAQM's special intensive inspection drive in Ghaziabad's Loni under Operation Clean Air found all 28 inspected premises non-compliant with applicable environmental norms, officials said on Wednesday.

Waterlogging: PWD, NDMC at odds

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, August 26

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh has outlined Delhi's short and long-term plans to tackle waterlogging, as a blame game has emerged within the BJP-led government a day after heavy rain inundated several parts of the Capital, with officials of the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), speaking anonymously to some media, pointing to alleged shortcomings in the Public Works Department's desilting work. The minister however, defended the department's efforts and outlined that the number of waterlogging spots has fallen from around 308 earlier to 115 currently.

Of the current locations, 60 fall under the PWD's jurisdiction. Work at 39 of these sites is being taken up through immediate mea-

“WHEN THERE IS SUDDENLY TOO MUCH RAIN, THE CAPACITY OF DRAINS IS LESS, SO IT TAKES TIME FOR THE WATER TO PASS

sures, which the minister said would take around three to four months. The remaining 21 have been identified for permanent interventions that could take one to two years. "Earlier there were around 308 waterlogging spots. When we came to power, there were 169 points in 2025. Today, there are 115," Singh said, adding that the government was working on both immediate and permanent solutions.

He said the PWD was also preparing a new Drain-

age Master Plan, taking into account Delhi's present and projected requirements. According to Singh, the existing drainage infrastructure was designed for a much smaller population and is inadequate when rainfall exceeds the carrying capacity of drains.

"When there is suddenly too much rain, the capacity of drains is less, so it takes time for the water to pass," he said. The minister added that water remaining on roads for 30-35 minutes would not necessarily be treated as waterlogging, while prolonged accumulation for two hours or more would be considered a serious waterlogging situation. Singh said large drains were also being constructed as part of the broader drainage planning exercise. "At each spot, work is under progress. The situation is much better than pre-

vious years," he said.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday said Delhi's drainage network was more than five decades old and stressed the need to address structural deficiencies rather than relying only on temporary measures. She said the government was pursuing a Rs.56,000-crore master plan covering drainage, sewerage and water infrastructure. Meanwhile, Traffic Police data has identified 21 locations that have repeatedly faced inundation during successive monsoons. PWD had also listed 448 vulnerable locations in May for preventive measures ahead of the rainy season. The PWD maintains around 1,400 km of arterial roads in Delhi and works with civic agencies, including the MCD and NDMC, on drainage, desilting and flood-control measures during the monsoon.

Treat waterlogging as
disaster: L-G to officials

'Prioritise real-time redressal of complaints'

SHIVANGI SHUKLA
New Delhi, August 26

Delhi L-G Sardar TS Sandhu has directed all concerned departments and agencies to treat the waterlogging situation in the Capital as a disaster requiring a war-footing response, ordering the installation of pumps to be expedited across identified vulnerable points so that waterlogging does not occur in the first place.

Reviewing the situation at a late evening meeting on Tuesday following heavy and record down-pour within a short span across various locations, the L-G directed departmental and agency heads to remain actively present on the ground round the clock. He said a "whole of government" approach was non-negotiable, with all departments and agencies required to work in com-



plete synergy rather than in silos. Sandhu also directed all heads to be physically present on the streets during flooding situations to personally oversee remedial measures instead of monitoring developments from their offices.

The meeting was attended by the CEO of Delhi Jal Board, Principal Secretary (PWD), Chair-

From doorsteps
to drones, MCD's
dengue war

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, August 26

As Delhi enters the time of year when mosquito numbers usually rise, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi is using new technology and ground checks to stop diseases like dengue before they spread. So far this year, the city has reported 272 cases of dengue, 95 cases of malaria, and 21 cases of chikungunya, with no deaths reported from these three diseases. However, weekly numbers are slowly going up, with 26 new dengue cases and 15 new malaria cases recorded in the week ending.

One of the biggest problems for workers is reaching difficult areas, such as large swamps, dense weeds, and locked or hidden spaces where mosquitoes lay eggs. To solve this, the civic body started using flying drones to spray mosquito medicine over Naini Lake in Model Town. Mayor Praveesh Wahi explained that in places like swamps where a person cannot easily go to spray medicine, special arrangements have been made, adding that drone spraying will soon expand to other lakes and along the banks of the Yamuna River.

Along with aerial spraying, city teams are conducting massive door-to-door checks on the ground. Health inspectors have already found mosquito breeding spots at more than 100,000 locations, issued over 81,000 legal warnings to property owners, and filed nearly 7,000 legal cases for unchecked breeding. In addition, workers have carried out anti-larval indoor spraying inside more than 350,000 homes across the capital.



NDMC apologises
for waterlogging
after heavy rain

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 26

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) apologised to residents on Wednesday for waterlogging following heavy rain in the area over the last two days, saying it will strengthen its systems to prevent a repeat of the disruption.

NDMC chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi said the civic body was usually able to clear waterlogging within 15-20 minutes, but the situation was different at three to four locations on Tuesday, where it took more than an hour for the water to drain. "More than 72 mm of rainfall was recorded in less than two hours," Dwivedi said in a post on X, describing the intensity of the spell as "unexpected".

"Usually we can clear the waterlogging within 15-20 minutes. But despite our best efforts in at least 3-4 areas water was fully drained out in more than an hour," he said.

However, Dwivedi said the heavy rain could not be used as an excuse for the inconvenience caused to residents. "This cannot be an excuse and we will have to strengthen our systems to deal with such situations in future."

He also invited suggestions from residents on improving the system.

According to officials, the council received doz-

Union MoS Harsh Malhotra said the launch represented the fulfilment of a commitment made by the government. "The Delhi Lakshmi Yojna is a historic step towards fulfilling Prime Minister Modi Ji's guarantee," he said, adding that the scheme would help strengthen women's financial position and self-reliance.

L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu said the initiative would contribute to women's economic independence. "The Delhi Lakshmi Yojna is a historic step towards women's dignity, security and financial independence," he said.

The government said the assistance would be transferred directly into beneficiaries' bank accounts from September 1, allowing women to use the funds according to their needs and family expenses.

The launch event was attended by several Delhi ministers, Lok Sabha MPs, MLAs, councillors and senior government officials. Cultural performances and registration counters were also organised at the venue.

The scheme is among the Delhi government's key initiatives focused on providing financial support to women, with the government maintaining that the assistance is intended to strengthen their financial security and self-reliance.

Rain, but no
major snags

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

Delhi received light rain on Wednesday, a day after the national capital witnessed heavy showers that led to widespread waterlogging and traffic disruptions, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The city did not face major traffic disruptions on Wednesday as several establishments observed a public holiday and the rain was not widespread or heavy. The weather department issued a yellow alert for the evening and night, forecasting thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and light-to-moderate rainfall.

ens of complaints related to waterlogging, tree felling and power outages in the Lutyens' area in the last two days.

The national capital received more than 90 mm of rainfall at several weather stations, including Safdarjung, which recorded 99.1 mm of cumulative rainfall till 8:30 am on Tuesday, according to the weather department.

EIGHT-POINT CONSENSUS REACHED DURING TALKS

India & China agree to advance talks on boundary delimitation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Beijing, August 26

India and China have agreed to advance discussions on an “Early and Substantial Harvest” of boundary delimitation and border management during talks between National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing.

The Indian Embassy said this in a statement on Wednesday, a day after Doval and Wang held the 25th round of Special Representatives (SR) talks on the boundary question in Beijing.

During the talks, both sides reached eight points of outcomes and consensus, the statement said.

Later in the night, the Chinese Foreign Ministry also released the same eight-point consensus reached between the two sides.

“Both sides underlined their commitment to advancing negotiations on a framework for the settlement of the boundary question in accordance with the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question signed in 2005 and the consensus reached in subsequent SR Talks in pursuit of a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable solution”



CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘Both sides underlined their commitment to advancing negotiations on a framework for the settlement of the boundary question in accordance with the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question signed in 2005 and the consensus reached in subsequent SR Talks in pursuit of a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable solution’
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ment on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the India-

China Boundary Question signed in 2005 and the con-

sensus reached in subsequent SR Talks in pursuit of a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable solution,” the statement said.

“The Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation under the WMCC (Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China border affairs) would respectively advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation and Border Management,” it said.

“The first task for both these groups would be to agree on their respective Terms of Reference,” the statement said.

Held under the framework of SR dialogue, the Doval-Wang talks came weeks before President Xi Jinping’s anticipated visit to India for the upcoming BRICS summit.

“The two sides agreed that any situation on the ground would be addressed promptly through existing

diplomatic and military channels, including the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China border affairs (WMCC), local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms, to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the LAC,” the statement said.

“The two sides discussed ways to improve understanding of LAC (Line of Actual Control) in appropriate areas, for better border management,” it said.

“With the objective to improve the border management measures, an additional two meeting points were agreed for holding the General Level Mechanism/Senior Highest Military Commander meeting (SHMC). Similarly two additional channels of border military hotline in the Eastern and Middle Sectors were agreed,” it said.

Also, the two sides agreed

to hold the next meeting of the India-China Expert-Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers in September and maintain communication on issues, including hydrological data sharing, and renewal of the relevant MoUs.

India and China established the Expert Level Mechanism (ELM) in 2006 to discuss various issues related to trans-border rivers under which China provides India with hydrological information on the Brahmaputra River and Sutlej River during the flood seasons.

The statement issued by both sides noted the progress on trans-border cooperation.

“The Indian side appreciated the efforts made by the Chinese side to increase the number of batches of Indian official pilgrimage Kailash-Manasarovar Yatra (KMY) in the Tibet Autonomous Region of China,” it said.

“Both sides appreciated the reopening of the three designated border trading

points. The two sides agreed to strengthen exchanges and cooperation in border trade, pilgrimage and other areas, with the view to work together to create an atmosphere featuring dialogue, peace, consultation and cooperation in the border areas,” it said.

The two sides reaffirmed their commitment to uphold the guidance received from the leaders of the two countries, maintain peace and tranquility in the border areas and create an atmosphere for healthy and steady development of bilateral relations, it said.

Both sides agreed to hold the 26th round of SR Talks in India in 2027.

Both Doval and Wang are the designated SRs for the boundary talks mechanism, which was established in 2003 to comprehensively address the dispute of the India-China border spanning 3,488 km.

From page 1

TMC MPs

Bagchi and V Mohana, subsequently issued notices to the 20 MPs. It made clear that the issue before it was not merely whether notices should be served, but whether the proceedings could be brought to a conclusion within a specified timeframe. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Speaker and the Lok Sabha Secretary General, told the court that he had instructions to inform it that notices had already been issued. In view of this, the court did not issue notices to the Speaker’s office or the Secretary General.

The disqualification petitions stem from the rebellion of 20 TMC MPs, who have joined or merged with the Tripura-based Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) and sought recognition as a separate group in the Lok Sabha. TMC has argued that the MPs’ move amounts to voluntarily giving up membership of the party and attracts the anti-defection law.

Banerjee had first approached Birla on July 27 and met him again on August 12, alleging prolonged inaction. The Supreme Court will consider the matter further after the MPs respond to its notices.

Nearly 160 dead

earthquake struck the Tibet region at 8:37 am local time and reports of flash flooding followed three minutes later. The timing raised the possibility that the tremors triggered a glacial outburst, although authorities have not established the cause conclusively. The National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said a rockslide and the swelling of the Lhende River along the Nepal-Tibet border caused the floodwaters to enter the Trishuli River through the Bhote Koshi at Timure in Rasuwa district. The Department of Hydrology and Meteorology said the flooding was not caused by rainfall in Rasuwa.

The force of the water caused widespread destruction. Videos from the affected areas showed torrents carrying mud, rocks and debris through settlements, with residents fleeing as the water approached buildings, vehicles and bridges. One video showed a four-storey structure being swept away, while another captured a car floating in the floodwaters in Rasuwa. Several bridges were shown collapsing under the force of the current.

In Dhading, footage showed floodwaters hitting a bridge before bringing it down. Another video showed a bridge being engulfed by muddy water and swept away in about 30 seconds. The government later said 19 motorable bridges had been destroyed in the floods.

The Kathmandu Post reported that flooding in the

Bhote Koshi also washed away the 42-km road connecting Betrawati in Nuwakot with the Rasuwagadhi border crossing in Rasuwa, disrupting an important route to the border.

The human toll also included foreign tourists and security personnel. Officials said at least 50 of the missing Indian nationals were pilgrims travelling for the Kailash Manasarovar Yatra. Other missing tourists were from more than two dozen countries, including the United States, Malaysia, Britain, South Africa, Australia and the Netherlands. In addition, 80 security personnel, including 44 Nepal Army personnel, were reported missing from different locations, Khanal told Parliament.

Around 160 people were rescued from various affected areas, with 30 receiving treatment at Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital in Kathmandu.

The flooding also damaged Nepal’s power infrastructure. The Independent Power Producers’ Association Nepal said eight operational hydropower projects with a combined capacity of 354 MW were damaged, along with five projects under construction in Nuwakot and Rasuwa. Among the affected operational plants were the 111-MW Rasuwagadhi Hydropower Project, 78-MW Sanjen Khola Hydropower Project and 60-MW Upper Trishuli 3A project.

Authorities warned that the danger had not passed. Nepal’s Flood Forecasting Division said information from China indicated that a lake formed at a river blockage site had not yet fully drained. It warned that the risk remained in the Bhote Koshi and Trishuli areas and advised people to stay away from rivers and remain in safe locations until further updates.

The Nepal Army, Armed Police Force and Nepal Police were deployed for rescue and relief operations following an emergency meeting chaired by Prime Minister Shah. The government said Shah expressed condolences to families of those killed and wished those injured a speedy recovery, while directing officials to provide necessary assistance to affected people.

The Nepal Army deployed 12 helicopters for search and rescue operations. Six people were rescued from Syaphrubesi, two from Mailung and four from Dhunche, all in Rasuwa, according to an Army statement. A treatment centre was also established at Military Training Centre No 1 in Trishuli, where Army medical personnel were treating people affected by the disaster. An MI-17 helicopter carrying an Emergency Medical Rescue Team was sent towards the district hospital in Trishuli.

Across the border, Chinese President Xi Jinping ordered an all-out search and rescue operation for those missing in the floods. A total of 145 officers and soldiers from the Xigaze detachment of the People’s Armed Police were sent to the affected

border port for emergency response work. Xi called for residents at risk to be evacuated, injured people to receive timely medical care and monitoring and early warning systems to be strengthened to prevent further casualties and secondary disasters. State-run Global Times reported that local authorities had sent personnel to the disaster-hit area, where communities had been disrupted. Nepalese President Ramchandra Paudel also expressed sorrow over the loss of life and property in Rasuwa and Nuwakot. The latest disaster has revived memories of previous flooding along the Bhote Koshi. Last year, two major floods struck the river, causing extensive damage in Rasuwa and killing at least 10 people.

Shah speaks to CMs

Trishuli river at Furke Khola in Nepal, around 160 km from the Indian border, following suspected flash-flood and Glacial Lake Outburst Flood activity near the Nepal-China border. It said water levels in reservoirs on the Nepal side were declining and the situation was under control. The Union Home Ministry said there was no panic-like situation, but warned that floodwaters could travel downstream through the Gandak river in India.

Shah said the NDRF had been placed on high alert along with local administrations and relief and rescue teams in border areas. Officials from the Ministries of Home Affairs, External Affairs, Jal Shakti and Defence were monitoring developments. The Bihar and Uttar Pradesh governments have also begun evacuations and other support measures for communities living near the India-Nepal border.

In Bihar, special vigilance has been ordered in West Champaran, East Champaran, Gopalganj, Saran, Muzaffarpur and Vaishali, as well as vulnerable districts including Sitamarhi and Sheohar. All 36 gates of the Gandak Barrage at Valmikinagar were opened to facilitate the movement of water.

Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Choudhary, who also holds the Water Resources Department portfolio, said about 86,000 cusecs of water was released from the barrage around noon. A technical team headed by a Superintending Engineer has been deployed there, while warnings have been sent to districts along the Gandak basin. Choudhary said Bihar would need to remain alert through the night.

Bihar Chief Secretary Pratya Amrit reviewed the situation with district magistrates and senior police officers from border districts. Authorities were told to keep evacuation plans, boats, shelters and community kitchens ready and complete rescue and relief preparations.

In Uttar Pradesh, Yogi Adityanath directed the administrations of Maharajganj and Kushinagar to prepare for any rise in the Gandak and Narayani rivers. Maharajganj ordered round-the-clock monitoring of the Gandak and made arrangements to shift residents from vulnerable low-lying and riverside areas to safer locations if necessary. Kushinagar authorities ordered evacuations from Marchahwa, Shivpur and other villages, with public announcements urging residents to move to safer areas. Special vigilance is being maintained in Shivpur, Hariharpur, Narayanpur, Marchahwa and Basantpur in Khadda tehsil because rainfall in Nepal could raise the Narayani river level. The Sashastra Seema Bal has alerted formations along the 1,751-km India-Nepal border and deployed 18 teams for relief and rescue operations. Additional NDRF and SDRF teams, boats and other resources will be sent wherever required.

The floods in Nepal originated in the Bhote Koshi River after a surge from the Tibet region. Rasuwa and Dhading, followed by Nuwakot and Chitwan, were among the affected districts. At least four permanent bridges and several temporary bridges were damaged, while around a dozen hydropower projects were also affected.

India sends relief

while downstream areas including Nuwakot also faced the impact as the water moved towards the Trishuli river valley.

Rasuwa suffered some of the worst destruction, particularly around Timure, Rasuwagadhi and Syaphrubesi near the Nepal-China border. Houses, roads, bridges and government buildings were damaged or washed away, while transport and connectivity in the strategically important border region were severely disrupted.

The floods also affected hydropower infrastructure. At least a dozen hydropower projects were damaged or crippled, with reports indicating that around 430 MW of generation capacity has been affected. The damage is expected to affect electricity production as rescue teams continue to assess the scale of destruction.

Casualty and missing-person figures remained fluid as rescue operations continued. Nepalese authorities said 95 bodies had been recovered and around 500 people were missing. Other reports put the number of missing people at more than 750, including 133 Indian nationals. An earlier assessment from officials in Rasuwa said nearly 400 people were missing, including 105 Indians and 37 non-resident Indians. On the Chinese side of the border, state-run CGTN reported three deaths and 265 people missing following the flooding in the Tibet region.

Indian officials said the full extent of the disaster was still being assessed and that casualty figures could change as rescue teams reached areas cut off by the floods.

The cause of the sudden surge of water was not immediately established. Nepalese meteorological authorities said the flooding was not caused by local rainfall in Rasuwa, prompting attention towards possible upstream causes in Tibet. Possibilities under consideration include heavy rainfall upstream, a landslide or an avalanche blocking the river and a subsequent sudden release of accumulated water. Authorities are continuing to assess the circumstances. The Nepal government has deployed the Nepal Army, Nepal Police, Armed Police Force, helicopters and disaster response teams for rescue and relief work. The mountainous terrain, damaged roads and high water levels have made access to several affected locations difficult. Indian authorities have also been monitoring the situation because several rivers originating in Nepal flow downstream into India. Water levels and the possibility of downstream effects are being watched as the flood situation develops.

The Indian Embassy in Kathmandu said it was working with Nepalese authorities to secure the early rescue and relief of Indian nationals affected by the disaster. It issued emergency contact numbers, +977 985 131 6807 and +977 970 910 7500, both of which can also be reached through WhatsApp.

The Indian Embassy in Beijing separately issued an advisory for Indians stranded near the Tibet-Nepal border. It said affected nationals could contact Chinese officials on the ground at 0086 139 8999 0012, the Embassy of India in Beijing at 0086 185 1428 4905, including through WhatsApp, or the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu through its emergency numbers.

“The Embassy in Beijing is in close touch with local authorities to assist affected Indian nationals. Please follow all official advisories issued by local authorities,” the mission said.

Nepal Foreign Minister Shirsir Khanal thanked India and Jaishankar for the assistance. “Thank you Hon. EAM @DrJaishankar and the Government of India for the generous humanitarian aid and critical medical supplies extended to support our flood relief operations,” he said. Khanal added that India’s response reflected the bilateral partnership between the two countries.

The Indian missions have advised nationals in affected areas to follow instructions issued by local authorities. With rescue teams still working to reach isolated settlements and the extent of infrastructure damage being assessed, authorities in both Nepal and India said efforts would continue as more information emerged.

Meanwhile, following the disaster in Nepal, the West Bengal government has opened a helpline at the state police headquarters in Bhawani Bhawan to assist residents of the state who are currently in Nepal. The helpline numbers are (033) 24793311 and 9147890181.

‘UP tops pendency list

Odisha, Rajasthan, Telangana, Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya and Nagaland. Among the UTs, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, Ladakh and Lakshadweep had no functional FTCs. The backlog has fluctuated over the past five years. There were 11.73 lakh pending cases across 898 courts in 2021, rising to 14.74 lakh in 2022 despite the number of courts falling to 848.

Pendency reached 15.27 lakh in 2023, when around 15.21 lakh cases were disposed of. It fell to 14.57 lakh in 2024 before rising to 14.70 lakh in 2025, when around 13.3 lakh cases were disposed of. In the first six months of 2026, more than 8.66 lakh cases were disposed of, but the overall pendency rose to 17.54 lakh by June 30.

Centre says onion

The all-India average retail price of onion stood at Rs 46.74 per kg on Wednesday, 35 per cent higher than a month earlier and 63 per cent above the level recorded a year ago.

“Onion availability is comfortable to meet domestic demand in the coming months,” the department said. Onion production is estimated at 307.37 lakh tonnes in 2025-26, nearly unchanged from 307.67 lakh tonnes in the previous year.

The government has procured around 1.21 lakh tonnes for the buffer stock. The Central Warehousing Corporation has been appointed as the storage agency for the onion buffer for the first time in 2026-27.

Retail onions are being sold at Rs 35 per kg through NCCF and NAFED outlets and mobile vans, along with Safal and Kendriya Bhandar outlets in Delhi. NCCF is using 90 outlets and 40 mobile vans, while NAFED has 13 outlets and 50 mobile vans. About 100 Kendriya Bhandar outlets are also participating.

The Kanda Express initiative is transporting buffer onions from Nashik to Delhi NCR. Supplies are also being sent to Chennai, Kolkata, Ernakulam, Guwahati, Varanasi, Lucknow, Patna, Chandigarh, Jammu and Amritsar. The department said the quantity and distribution channels would be expanded depending on market conditions. Onion exports during April-June 2026 were about 3.82 lakh tonnes. It also said daily prices of 41 essential commodities are monitored across 579

centres. Prices of major pulses, tomato and potato are currently stable, while the department warned that rumours about exceptionally high food prices were being spread to create panic among consumers. MPOST

Balyan shot dead

According to police, the attackers arrived on two motorcycles and fired several rounds at Balyan. He died at the spot. Superintendent of Police M P Singh said the body had been sent for post-mortem examination and police teams were formed to arrest those responsible. CCTV footage from the area is also being examined.

There was speculation that Balyan was planning to contest the upcoming panchayat polls, but authorities and his associates had not confirmed it or whether it was linked to the killing. Balyan had more than 3.66 lakh YouTube subscribers and appeared in videos as a singer and performer. Several of his videos featured guns, firearms and SUVs. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav condemned the killing, saying 18 rounds were fired and claiming the incident showed the law-and-order situation in Uttar Pradesh had been reduced to “zero”. He called for an investigation into possible political rivalry and said the Jat community viewed the killing as an attack on itself. MPOST

High Court directs UP

The court said the decision did not even consider the family’s request to be relocated to Ghaziabad or Noida and therefore could not be treated as compliance with its earlier order.

The Additional Chief Secretary (Home) has been asked to file a compliance affidavit. If the directions are not followed, the officer will have to appear personally before the court on November 30. The court noted that it had earlier asked the state to consider the family’s request for relocation to Ghaziabad or Noida, but the government had instead proposed the three districts near Hathras. Advocate Mahmood Pracha, appearing for the family, told the court that the proposed districts raised safety concerns as they are close to Hathras and the family has no relatives there. The family has relatives in Ghaziabad and Noida, he said, and relocation there would allow them to live without fear.

The bench observed that there appeared to be “unnecessary resistance” from the state and said its approach lent credence to the family’s contention that the government was treating the proceedings as adversarial litigation.

The 19-year-old woman was allegedly raped by four men from her village in September 2020. She died at a Delhi hospital about a fortnight later.

Briefs

Tejashwi meets injured protestors

PATNA: Bihar Leader of Opposition Tejashwi Yadav on Wednesday met students who were injured during an agitation here over alleged inconsistencies in competitive exams.

He visited Patna Medical College and Hospital (PMCH) and spoke to the injured protestors undergoing treatment there.

Badal slams jailed MP Amritpal

MALOUT: Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) president Sukhbir Singh Badal on Wednesday attacked jailed Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh, alleging that he wanted to take Punjab back to the 1980s when no one was safe.

Badal was addressing the second phase of his party's 'Punjab Bachao' (Save Punjab) campaign here. It was his first public address after he was attacked in Nanded in Maharashtra.

'Attire matter of personal choice'

PATNA: Asserting that attire was a matter of personal choice and guided by religious traditions, Union minister Chirag Paswan on Wednesday said there should have been "no interference in such matters".

The Lok Jan-shakti Party (Ram Vilas) president was responding to questions about the Allahabad High Court order dismissing a plea by a girl seeking permission to wear a hijab along with her school uniform at her school in Prayagraj.

UPTET 2026 result declared

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh Education Services Selection Commission (UPSESSC) on Wednesday declared the results of the UPTET 2026, with more than 13.3 lakh candidates qualifying the teacher eligibility examination held across 60 districts.

The qualifying percentage stood at 80.07 per cent for the primary level and 71.85 per cent for the upper-primary level, the commission said.

UNEP India outlines plans

NEW DELHI: With India having recently recognised heatwaves as a natural calamity, the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) in India said translating intent, assessments, and science into real action on the ground, and turning accessible financing into concrete, implementable projects more swiftly, are among the key priorities going forward.

KHELO INDIA DIALOGUE

PM to motivate youth to take up sports, shape India's future

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 26

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will interact with youth at the 'Khelo India Dialogue' on Thursday as part of efforts to engage with them on the country's sporting journey, share their aspirations, and contribute ideas for a stronger youth-led 'Viksit Bharat'.

The virtual address of Modi at the 'Khelo India Dialogue' will be structured around five themes of sport, Olympic aspirations, youth leadership, Viksit Bharat and 'Nasha Mukht Yuva'.

Improving India's sports ecosystem, coaching, inclusive participation and nurturing talent for the 2036 Olympics via scientific talent identification, transparent selection and long-term athlete development are also part of the objectives of the dialogue.

The programme aims to help the youth engage with India's sporting journey, share their aspirations, and contribute ideas for a stronger youth-led Viksit Bharat, a statement issued by the prime minister's office said.

It will provide a direct channel for young people to engage with the country's sporting ambitions, while ensuring that their ideas and perspectives become part of the con-



PM Narendra Modi

HIGHLIGHTS

- » PM's virtual address will be structured around five themes of sport, Olympic aspirations, youth leadership, Viksit Bharat and 'Nasha Mukht Yuva'
- » The nationwide Khelo India Dialogue will bring together sports, youth leadership, civic responsibility, volunteering, fitness and nation-building on a common platform

tinuing conversation on India's youth and sports ecosystem.

Organised by Mera Yuva Bharat (MY Bharat) as part of the National Sports Day 2026 celebrations, the programme will be conducted across the country with participation of youth at two colleges in every district across States and Union Territories.

The programme is being held in line with the Prime Minister's vision of building a fit, disciplined and sporting nation

while placing the aspirations of youth at the centre of the national development agenda.

The nationwide Khelo India Dialogue will bring together sports, youth leadership, civic responsibility, volunteering, fitness and nation-building on a common platform.

The national programme will be followed by local interactions involving young participants, MY Bharat volunteers, local sportspersons and public representatives.

Meghalaya: Resolution passed against mining of uranium

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Shillong, August 26

The Meghalaya Assembly on Wednesday passed a resolution against exploration and mining of uranium in the northeastern state.

The Assembly adopted the resolution moved by Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma and supported by all 60 MLAs.

The resolution urged the Centre, the Department of Atomic Energy and Uranium Corporation of India Ltd (UCIL) not to permit, pursue or undertake any uranium mining operation in Meghalaya.

"We have seen the impacts of uranium mining in different parts of the country, where the health of people around mining areas has been affected," Sangma said.

AHEAD OF IAEA'S ATLAS LAUNCH

India, US discuss developments in civil nuclear cooperation

AGENCIES

Washington, August 26

Top officials from India and the US on Wednesday discussed developments in bilateral civil nuclear space and ways to further strengthen cooperation in the area.

Atomic Energy Commission Chairman Ajit Kumar Mohanty held discussions with US Energy Secretary Chris Wright here ahead of the ministerial launch of IAEA's Atomic Technologies Licensed for Applications at Sea (ATLAS) initiative.

Mohanty, who is also Secretary, Department of Atomic Energy, is in the US for the launch of an initiative of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) to explore the use of small modular reactors to power civilian ships.

"The discussions focused on the ongoing developments in bilateral



civil nuclear space and policy measures to further strengthen India-US Civil Nuclear Cooperation for mutual benefit of both the sides," the Department of Atomic Energy said in a post on X.

The meeting comes against the backdrop of India opening up its civil nuclear energy sector for private players as it eyes to build 100 GW of nuclear power capacity by 2047.

Several US firms in the nuclear energy sector have evinced interest in the Indian market and are exploring avenues for investments and partnerships.

The ATLAS initiative of the IAEA will support the maritime industry's exploration of small modular reactors (SMRs) to power civilian ships and to provide offshore energy, as operators consider alternative fuels and seek to strengthen long-term energy security.

The ATLAS Launch Event is expected to establish strong momentum and visibility for the initiative by securing high-level political endorsement and fostering engagement across the nuclear and maritime sectors, the IAEA said.

The discussions are expected to deliver a shared understanding and validation of priority actions related to legal and regulatory frameworks, safety, security, safeguards and liability, while strengthening collaboration between the nuclear and maritime sectors.

UP: Free bus travel to women over 60

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Lucknow, August 26

Women aged 60 years and above will now be able to travel free of cost on Uttar Pradesh Roadways buses under the newly launched Lokmata Ahilyabai Matri Shakti Yatra scheme.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath launched the scheme at an event held at the Indira Gandhi Pratishthan in Lucknow on Wednesday. The gov-

ernment estimates that around 88,438 women passengers will benefit from the scheme every day.

Under the scheme, the Uttar Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation will issue special smart cards to eligible women aged 60 and above. The cards will help identify beneficiaries and facilitate their free travel on Roadways buses.

Announcing the scheme, Adityanath said it had been named after

Ahilyabai Holkar, whom he described as a symbol of courage and self-respect. He also announced a special travel facility for Raksha Bandhan. On August 27, 28 and 29, women will be allowed to travel free on Roadways buses along with one companion.

After the three-day Raksha Bandhan facility, free travel will be available to every woman aged 60 years and above under the new scheme.

EC renews outreach plans for Gen Alpha, Z

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 26

The Election Commission (EC) has initiated renewed efforts to reach out to Gen Alpha and Z ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha polls to make them aware voters who are well-acquainted with the electoral process and can lead future campaigns to educate people.

As part of its revamped campaign, the poll authority will target schoolchildren from classes 9 to 12, colleges and universities across the 4,123 Assembly constituencies of India.

According to EC officials, there are a total of 14.78 crore people in the 18-26 age group, including 7.98 crore males, 6.79 crore females and 9,000 third gender.

The poll authority plans to set up 50,000 Electoral Literacy Clubs (ELCs) with 10 such bodies per Assembly constituency, the officials said.

For this, it will contact students of classes 9 to 12 in 15 lakh schools. Besides, it will reach out to 70,000 colleges and 1,400 universities.

ELCs were set up in 2018 as part of the Systematic Voters' Education and Electoral Participation (SVEEP) programme to introduce students to democratic values, the electoral process and the role and functioning of the EC.

However, in view of the rapidly evolving communication ecosystem, increasing reliance on digital platforms and the need for sustained, structured and direct engagement with young electors and grassroots stakeholders, ELC 2.0 reimagines these clubs as a digitally enabled, structured and continuously engaging framework.



Police personnel try to evict protesting students, in Patna, Bihar PTI

sition in Lok Sabha, said the students in Bihar have a very straightforward question: Why are there irregularities in recruitment exams?

"Why no action on allegations of paper leaks? And how long will this tampering with the future of the youth continue?" he asked.

"The controversy over BPSC exams is not of today. Students have been on the streets for a long time over the recruitment process, exam pattern, delays, and transparency. But instead of answering, what is the gov-

ernment doing? It's wielding batons and water cannons. It's taking students into custody," Gandhi said.

In Siwan, there was even firing on protesters with an AK-47, he said.

"This is not just a question of police action; this is a question of the mindset of the BJP government, which has no answers. That is why it is turning the police into a weapon to evade accountability," Gandhi alleged.

He said the BJP government should understand that questions don't stop with batons.

ONE STEP FOR THE FUTURE

Gen Alpha rise to demand accountability, better infra

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 26

The summer of student discontent is moving into autumn... from Jantar Mantar to obscure muddy paths, from the heart of the Indian capital to villages and towns fighting for a place on the education map, and from Gen Z to Gen Alpha.

And the sounds of protests are getting ever louder.

Picking up from the June-July Cockroach Janta Party-led agitation focusing on alleged corruption in NEET exams, hundreds



School students form a human chain as they stage a protest against poor facilities and shortage of teachers, at Balaganj Circle, in Lucknow PTI

of much younger school students have taken to the streets to highlight their problems. Bringing up

issues such as no fans, no toilets, no teachers and no infrastructure, not even a proper building.

KEY POINTS

- » Across India's social and political landscape, Gen Alpha students - those born between 2010 and 2024 - have taken it upon themselves to improve their learning environments
- » "We are not here to fight, but we will neither retreat nor be intimidated," BJP's Ranka said

Across India's social and political landscape, Gen Alpha students - those born between 2010 and 2024 -

have taken it upon themselves to improve their learning environments. The reports have come in from Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh with students finding their voice, even in the midst of adverse circumstances, to spotlight problems that are immediate and personal.

A major win came last week from a primary school in a village in Rajasthan's Jaipur where students were attending classes from a cattle enclosure. Following a confrontation between members of the BJP, who wanted to inspect

a school in Rampura Kanwarpura village, and some villagers, the state government announced the construction of a new building.

The Rampura school building, it admitted, was declared dilapidated in September 2025 and classes were being held in a cattle enclosure.

Reacting to the announcement, BJP co-founder and spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka said the party's immediate demand over the Rampura school had been addressed, but its campaign on the condition of government schools would continue.

VB-G RAM G PLANS

Centre asks states to integrate water and sanitation works

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 26

The Centre has asked states and Union territories to integrate drinking water source sustainability, grey-water management and sanitation works with the VB-G RAM G rural employment guarantee scheme.

The directive was issued earlier this month through a joint letter by the Ministry of Jal Shakti and the Ministry of Rural Development, which asked states and UTs to ensure convergence of resources for water security and sanitation and outlined measures for integrated planning, implementation and monitoring of such works.

The letter said water security has been identified as one of the four thematic focus areas under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025.

The ministries directed that drinking water source sustainability works under Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) 2.0, greywater management interventions and sanitation and solid and liquid waste management (SLWM) works under Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen) 2.0 be integrated into Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans (VGPPs) under the appropriate thematic categories of the Act.

The implementation must be guided by water



KEY POINTS

- » The implementation must be guided by water budgeting, local resource assessment and water security plans
- » States and UTs may also nominate dedicated nodal officers from the state water and sanitation mission and the rural development department

budgeting, local resource assessment and water security plans.

The states were asked to give due priority to groundwater recharge, rainwater harvesting, rejuvenation of water bodies, watershed development, check dams, recharge structures, spring-shed management and other decentralised water conservation measures, particularly in water-stressed areas.

The letter recommended that the additional chief secretary, principal secretary or secretary in charge of the rural water

supply/public health engineering department should be included in the state-level steering committee constituted under the Act.

States and UTs may also nominate dedicated nodal officers from the state water and sanitation mission and the rural development department, with corresponding district-level nodal officers, to facilitate coordinated planning, technical scrutiny, implementation and monitoring of convergent activities.

The ministries further asked states to techni-

cally align village action plans prepared under JJM 2.0 and SBM (G) 2.0 with VGPPs before approval by the gram sabha, ensuring optimal utilisation of resources and avoiding duplication.

They directed that drinking water source sustainability works, sanitation assets, greywater management structures and other convergent assets be registered and geo-tagged on the Viksit Bharat National Rural Infrastructure Stack to facilitate integrated monitoring, transparency and evidence-based decision-making.

States were also encouraged to use geospatial planning tools such as Yuktdhara, along with water budgeting and hydrogeological assessments, to identify and prioritise water conservation interventions following the ridge-to-valley approach.

Himachal witnesses over 100 deaths in rain-related incidents this monsoon

The centre pegged the state loss to rain at Rs 1,176 crore

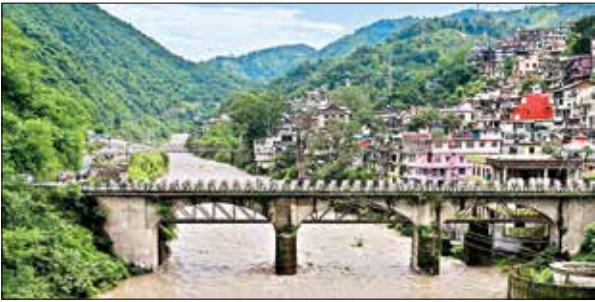
OUR CORRESPONDENT
Shimla, August 26

A total of 101 people have died in rain-related incidents in Himachal Pradesh since the onset of monsoon on June 30, the government said on Wednesday.

The rain-related incidents include flash floods, landslides, drowning, snake bites, electrocution and falling from height.

According to the data shared by the State Emergency Operations Centre, 16, the most, deaths were reported from Kangra district.

Fourteen each died in Lahaul and Spiti and Sirmaur, 13 each in Chamba and Shimla, 10 in Mandi, nine in Kullu, three each in Una, Kinnaur and Hamirpur, two in Bilaspur and



The Suketi rivulet flows in spate following rainfall, in Mandi district

one in Solan district in rain accidents.

The centre pegged the state loss to rain at Rs 1,176 crore.

Since Tuesday, Naina Devi received 86.4 mm of rainfall, Olinda 69.4 mm, Kangra 45.8 mm, Amb 38.8 mm, Nangal Dam 38.4 mm, Nalagarh 35 mm, Dharamshala 27.3 mm, Jogindernagar 26 mm and Dhaulakuan 25.5 mm

Thunderstorms and lightning lashed Sundernagar, Shimla, Kangra, Murari Devi and Jubberhatti.

The Shimla Met office on Wednesday issued a yellow warning of heavy rain in isolated areas of the state on September 1.

Eighty-two roads were closed for vehicular traffic in the state as on Wednesday evening, while 13 water supply schemes and five

THE RAIN-RELATED INCIDENTS INCLUDE FLASH FLOODS, LANDSLIDES, DROWNING, SNAKE BITES, ELECTROCUTION AND FALLING FROM HEIGHT

Mandi district

power transformers were scuppered.

Thirty-seven roads were closed in Mandi, 20 in Kullu, seven in Kangra, five each in Chamba and Sirmaur, four in Una, three in Shimla, and one in Lahaul and Spiti district.

Between August 1 and August 26, the state received 198.1 mm of rainfall against a normal of 227.2 mm, a deficit of 13 per cent.

DURING DURGA PUJA

DHR to start special joyride services

Maligaon, August 26

Darjeeling Himalayan Railway (DHR) a UNESCO World Heritage Site under Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) is set to introduce special additional joyride services from 1st October 2026 to make the upcoming Durga Puja festival season more memorable for tourists and visitors.

The initiative will offer enhanced opportunities to experience the historic railway, breathtaking landscapes and rich cultural heritage of the Darjeeling hills.

As part of the festival-season initiative, DHR will operate four single trip joyrides between Darjeeling and Ghum.

Services from Darjeeling to Ghum will depart at 9:20 am and 11:25 am, while services from Ghum to Darjeeling will depart at 10:25 pm and 12:30 pm. These services will be operated by diesel-hauled trains with a proposed fare of Rs 800 per single journey.

In addition, DHR

will introduce two special round trip joyrides between Kurseong and Mahanadi, providing passengers with an opportunity to enjoy one of the most scenic and heritage-rich sections of the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway.

The first service, "Red Panda" will be steam hauled and will depart from Kurseong at 9:00 am, return journey from Mahanadi at 10:00 am. The proposed fare for the round trip is Rs 1,530.

Cong turned Gurugram into a Millennium City, BJP ruined it: Hooda

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, August 26

Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda has stated that the BJP has completely ruined Gurugram, the 'Millennium City' developed by the Congress.

"During the Congress government's tenure, it was transformed into a modern, world-class IT hub, but the BJP has turned it into a vast expanse of water. Even a spell of light rain leaves roads, streets, and residential colonies submerged. The sewerage system collapses entirely, and there is absolutely no sign of any drainage or sanitation infrastructure," he said.

Hooda remarked that it is utterly ridiculous for a BJP Union minister to blame the Congress for Gurugram's dilapidated state, given that the BJP has been in power at both the state and centre for 12 years.

"Twelve years is a long time, enough to establish an entirely new city, yet the BJP has failed to even manage the infrastructure of a city that was already modern and well-established," he stated.

The former Chief Minister said that such water-logging, filth, and disarray were never witnessed in Gurugram during the Congress's tenure. However, since the BJP came to power, waterlogging, traffic jams, and hardships for the common people have become a recurring sight after every spell of rain.

Briefs

Teen dies after fall from terrace

KURUKSHETRA: A 16-year-old boy died during treatment at a hospital here after sustaining serious injuries in a fall from the terrace of a three-storey building, police said on Wednesday.

The family of Raman, a resident of Deha Colony here, however, alleged that two policemen pushed him from the terrace. Police denied the charge.

Raj: 3 killed as bus rams trailer

JAIPUR: Three people were killed and 10 others injured when a speeding private bus carrying around 35 passengers collided with a trailer while attempting to overtake it on National Highway-48 in Rajasthan's Udaipur district on Wednesday, police said.

Uttarakhand reports 57 H1N1 cases

DEHRADUN: Uttarakhand has reported 57 cases of H1N1 so far, with 52 of them detected in Dehradun, prompting the state government to direct districts to step up surveillance and ensure hospitals are equipped to deal with influenza and respiratory illnesses. State Director of Medical and Health Services Shikha Jangpangi said that 57 cases of Influenza A had been reported in the state till Tuesday.

NCB Jammu breaks up cross-border heroin cartel Seizes 5.16 kg drugs, 3 arrested

NARESH BISWANI
NEW DELHI

The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), Jammu has dismantled an alleged cross-border heroin trafficking cartel and arrested 3 people, including the suspected mastermind, in the process. The accused were allegedly smuggling heroin from Pakistan into Jammu.

The NCB acting on specific intelligence received on August 22, intercepted a vehicle at Panjtirthi in Jammu. The vehicle was searched and 5.160 kg of heroin was recovered from 2 of the accused, who are residents of Baramulla.

Following up on the leads received, the NCB started following up on the trail of another Baramulla resident, who is allegedly the mastermind and supplier of the heroin.

The accused was tracked down to Leh in Ladakh Union Territory and was arrested on

August 24, two days later.

As per initial investigations, the heroin recovered was part of a larger consignment that had been smuggled into India from Pakistan through the Uri border.

The NCB alleged that the accused was the mastermind behind the trafficking syndicate and that they had been tracking him down in order to bring the entire network to justice rather than just the couriers.

The NCB Jammu is currently conducting more investigations in order to track down the cross-border suppliers of heroin, money launderers, transporters, local buyers, and sellers associated with the cartel.

The seizure comes after 2 earlier recoveries of heroin by the NCB Jammu. The agency had recovered 438 grams of the drug on August 12 and another 603 grams the very next day.

Depinder Kaur takes charge as Member of Punjab Educational Tribunal



OUR CORRESPONDENT
Patiala, August 26

As per a notification issued by the Department of Higher Education, Government of Punjab, Dipinder Kaur, Principal (Retired), Mayor Shyam Lal Bansal, Member (Academic) of the Punjab Educational Tribunal.

The appointment has been made under the Punjab Educational Tribunal Act, 2007 and the relevant rules.

Her tenure will be for three years or until she attains the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier.

CM Saini honours Commonwealth Games medallists and participants

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, August 26

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday honoured the medallists and participating athletes of the Commonwealth Games 2026 at a state-level felicitation ceremony held in Panchkula.

On the occasion, 24 athletes were presented with cash awards amounting to Rs 13 crore 97 lakh 50 thousand.

Education minister Mahipal Dhandra, Minister of State for Sports Gaurav Gautam, Member of Parliament, Rekha Sharma, Mayor Shyam Lal Bansal, Principal Secretary, Sports Department, Amneet P Kumar, Director, Sports Department, Parth Gupta, athletes and their family members and other dignitaries were present on the occasion.

Expressing pride in the achievements of the athletes, the Chief Minister said an athlete's story does



Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini addresses the gathering, in Panchkula

not begin with a medal. It begins in the soil where they first learnt to run, on the field where they first experienced defeat, and on those mornings when the rest of the world was asleep while they were working towards their dream. Behind every athlete stands the faith of their parents, the discipline instilled by their coach and the determination to rise after every defeat. The world may see an athlete on the podium for a few moments, but what often remains unseen are the years of struggle that took them there, he said.

The Chief Minister said Haryana's athletes demon-

strated their strength and talent before the world in Glasgow. Today, every Haryana takes immense pride in their achievements, and their success has become a celebration across the state. The greatest quality of Haryana's soil, he said, is that it produces not only foodgrain in its fields, but champions as well.

The CM said Haryana accounts for barely 2 per cent of the country's total population, yet 24 of the 122 athletes who represented India at the Games were from Haryana, and nearly every second athlete from the state returned with a medal.

FROM NEXT ACADEMIC SESSION

Caste column to be removed from admission forms: CM Sukhu

Shimla, August 26

In a major step to remove caste-based discrimination, Himachal Pradesh's Congress government has decided to remove the caste column from admission forms in schools from the next academic session.

The move comes after several instances of caste-based discrimination in the schools, especially in the remote and rural areas of the state.

Recently the Himachal Pradesh State Commission for Scheduled Castes took cognisance of allegations that several students refused to eat food served by a Dalit girl student during a school event in the Cheog area of the Shimla district.

In another case of Shimla, an eight-year-old Dalit boy at a government primary school in the Khaddapani area of Rohru



Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu chairs a meeting of HPSCWB, in Shimla

was allegedly subjected to prolonged physical abuse and caste discrimination. The family alleged that teachers made Dalit and Nepali students sit separately from Rajput students during meals.

police later registered a case under relevant provisions, including the SC/ST Act

Chairing a meeting of Himachal Pradesh Scheduled Caste Welfare Board (HPSCWB) here, Chief Min-

CLOSER LOOK

- » The move comes after several instances of caste-based discrimination in the schools
- » The family alleged that teachers made Dalit and Nepali students sit separately from Rajput students during meals

ister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu said the state government was committed to eliminating caste-based discrimination in society and promoting a sense of fraternity and equality.

"Removing the caste column from school admission forms will be a step in this direction and would help ensure that children do not develop any sense of inferiority based on caste," said the chief minister.

Nevertheless, members of the scheduled caste community would continue to provide their caste details when availing themselves of government schemes

and benefits, ensuring that they receive the benefits of such schemes without any difficulty.

He assured that the state govt was prioritising efforts to resolve the issues faced by the scheduled caste community. Several schemes had been launched for the welfare of the community, and all eligible beneficiaries should be made aware of these initiatives so that they could avail themselves of the benefits available to them.

The chief minister informed that under the Rajiv Gandhi Start-up Swarozgar Saur Yojana, the state government was pro-

viding subsidies for setting up projects ranging from 100 kW to 2 MW. A subsidy of 5 per cent was being provided for projects in tribal areas and 4 per cent in other areas.

The state government was also providing loans of up to Rs 20 lakh to meritorious students for higher education at an interest rate of one per cent, so that students were not forced to discontinue their studies due to financial constraints.

He said the Himachal Pradesh govt would implement the Apna Parivar Sukhi Parivar Yojana for extremely poor families.

EDITORIAL

Degrees of Disconnect

India's higher education paradox is becoming harder to ignore. The country has expanded access to colleges and universities on an extraordinary scale, yet the connection between acquiring a degree and finding meaningful employment remains worryingly fragile. NITI Aayog's warning that crores of students continue to pursue conventional BA, BSc and BCom programmes with limited links to employment points to a problem deeper than graduate unemployment. Of roughly 3.4 crore undergraduate students, more than two crore are enrolled in these three streams, including about 1.13 crore pursuing BA courses. There is nothing inherently obsolete about arts, science or commerce education; indeed, a strong university system must educate citizens rather than merely manufacture workers. The problem arises when degrees become credentials pursued primarily because society and recruitment systems demand them, without providing either intellectual depth or marketable capabilities. The extraordinary competition for government employment illustrates this distortion. When nearly 1.86 crore applications can be submitted for just 55,000 government posts, higher education risks becoming a prolonged waiting room rather than a pathway to economic mobility.

The answer, however, cannot be to turn every university into a vocational training centre. India needs historians, economists, scientists, writers and researchers just as much as it needs technicians, programmers and managers. What requires reform is the rigid separation between academic education and employable skills. A commerce student should be able to graduate with competence in analytics, taxation or financial technology; an arts student should have pathways into communication, hospitality, public policy or digital industries; and science programmes should offer meaningful exposure to laboratories, manufacturing and applied technology. NITI Aayog's emphasis on specialised degrees, apprenticeship-embedded programmes and "earn-while-you-learn" models therefore deserves serious attention. Apprenticeships can provide something classrooms frequently cannot: familiarity with actual workplaces, deadlines, technology and professional expectations. Industry participation in curriculum design can also prevent courses from remaining frozen while the economy around them changes rapidly. But partnerships must supplement, rather than surrender, the educational mission of universities to immediate corporate requirements.

The larger reform must begin with how India measures educational success. Enrolment numbers, campuses constructed and degrees awarded reveal little about whether young people emerge capable of building sustainable careers. Institutions should increasingly be judged by learning outcomes, employability, apprenticeships, further education and career progression, while students need credible information about the employment record of different courses before choosing them. Government recruitment practices also require reconsideration where generic degrees are demanded for jobs that do not genuinely require them, because such requirements reinforce the race for credentials. India's demographic dividend will not last indefinitely. Every year spent moving millions of young people through programmes disconnected from economic opportunity carries a substantial personal and national cost. The objective should not be fewer graduates, nor the abandonment of broad education, but degrees that actually signify knowledge, capability and opportunity. Reimagining higher education is therefore not simply an education reform. It is central to whether India can turn the aspirations of its enormous young population into productive economic power.

LETTER



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Lives Washed Away

As a Nepali, it is heartbreaking to watch entire communities disappear beneath raging waters. The loss of lives, homes and livelihoods is not merely another disaster statistic; these are our families and neighbours. Nepal needs swift rescue efforts today, but also stronger warning systems and climate-resilient infrastructure for tomorrow.

MANISHA KHADKA,
KATHMANDU

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Power of a Second Chance

India Humanity Foundation's adult literacy programme is helping learners gain independence while strengthening families and creating educational opportunities

NEXUS OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND A FORMER CIVIL SERVANT

The day Madhabi Devi read a sentence on her own, she did something she had rarely done before – she read it aloud to her family.

A resident of South 24 Parganas, West Bengal, Madhabi had spent much of her life depending on others whenever she encountered written information. Forms, notices, instructions and numbers all meant asking someone else for help.

But at 34, she decided it was not too late to learn. She joined the Adult Literacy Programme of India Humanity Foundation (IHF). What began as a simple effort to learn the alphabet soon became something much bigger: a new sense of confidence, independence and possibility.

A second chance

Adult literacy is often associated with people who have spent most of their lives outside the formal education system. But there is an equally important group that deserves attention: adults aged 15 and above who still have several productive decades ahead of them.

For them, literacy is the first step towards understanding documents, managing money,



The power of literacy extends from individual learners to entire families

accessing information, improving livelihood opportunities and pursuing further education or vocational skills. A person who learns to read at 30, 35 or 40 may go on benefiting from that skill for the next thirty years or more.

For Madhabi, every new word expanded the world she could access independently. That is the opportunity IHF seeks to create.

Learning in vernacular

The programme is built around the realities of adult learners. Its structured curriculum covers reading, writing and basic mathematics through 60 learning sessions, with progress assessments along the way.

A key advantage is that the learning toolkits are available in vernacular languages, including Bengali, Hindi, Odia and Tamil, allowing learners to grasp concepts in the language they are most comfortable with.

The programme follows two models. Under Vidya, a trained community teacher, or Akshar Saathi, brings approximately 30 to 40

A SCALABLE LITERACY INITIATIVE SHOWS HOW TEACHING ONE ADULT CAN CREATE OPPORTUNITIES THAT EXTEND ACROSS GENERATIONS

adult learners together in a community space and conducts the structured sessions. Under Diksha – Each One, Teach One – a student from Class VI onwards teaches one adult learner from their neighbourhood for 45 to 60 minutes a day. Literacy thus becomes a bridge between generations.

The ripple effect

The impact of adult literacy does not stop with the person holding the primer. When a par-

ent becomes literate, the family begins to experience education differently.

A parent who can read a school notice engages more confidently with teachers. A mother who understands the importance of learning is more likely to see that her child attends school regularly. A literate family begins to treat education as an investment in the child's future rather than another household responsibility.

The sequence is a powerful one: one adult becomes literate, the family understands the value of education, children are encouraged to stay in school, the risk of dropout and child labour comes down, and the next generation starts from a stronger foundation.

In this way, adult literacy becomes an intervention not only for today's adults, but also for tomorrow's children.

Literacy heroes

Diksha creates an additional opportunity. A school student who teaches an adult learns far more than how to explain letters and

numbers; the experience builds responsibility, patience, communication and empathy.

IHF would like to see students who complete the programme and help an adult achieve literacy recognised as Literacy Heroes. The organisation also hopes that appropriate academic recognition, including rewarding students with extra marks for completing the prescribed programme, can encourage more young people to take part. Such recognition would reinforce an important message: helping another person become literate is itself an achievement.

Lifetime of possibilities at Rs 600

The Adult Literacy Programme has enrolled more than 4,00,000 adult learners across 22 states, working through literacy centres, student volunteers and partner organisations.

The model is designed to be replicated without elaborate infrastructure. A community space or school, appropriate learning materials, a committed teacher or student, and an adult willing to learn are enough to begin.

The cost of educating one adult is Rs 600. For that amount, an adult can acquire a skill that remains useful for decades, opening doors to greater independence, livelihood opportunities, further learning and fuller participation in family and community life.

Madhabi's journey began with a few letters. But literacy does not end with the ability to read a sentence. It begins there.

When one adult gets a second chance at education, an entire family can begin to see its future differently. And when thousands of such second chances come together, they can take India closer to the goal of becoming totally literate.

The model that India Humanity Foundation has put in place is a wonderful example of Nexus of Good. It can be replicated and scaled through public-private partnership. To know more about the programme, visit www.ihf.org.in.

Views expressed are personal

When Marriage Silences 'No'

Consent cannot lose its legal meaning simply because a woman is married

LEGAL PARADOX



AMAL CHANDRA & ANUSHA BHATTACHARJEE

BOTH WRITERS ARE POLITICAL AND SOCIAL COMMENTATORS

The law's promise of equality collides with the institution of marriage when a woman speaks no – and the law asks whether the man who ignored that no was her husband.

India's new criminal code, the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which came into force in July 2024, carried forward rather than resolved the contradiction inherited from the Indian Penal Code. Section 63 defines consent as an unequivocal, voluntary agreement to participate in a specific sexual act. Yet Exception 2 excludes from rape sexual intercourse or sexual acts by a man with his own wife, provided she is not under 18. The result is a stark legal asymmetry: outside marriage, non-consensual sex constitutes rape; within a marriage, the same violation is excluded from the rape provision. For a wife living separately, however, Section 67 criminalises non-consensual sexual intercourse by her husband, punishable with

imprisonment and a fine. The dividing line, therefore, is not consent but marital status.

The Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005, provides an important but incomplete safeguard. It recognises sexual abuse as domestic violence and enables protection, residence, monetary relief, custody and compensation orders. The law consequently acknowledges the wrong while withholding the legal recognition attached to the same violation outside marriage.

The scale of intimate-partner violence makes this legal gap impossible to dismiss as theoretical. NFHS-6, released in May 2026, records a welcome decline in spousal violence among ever-married women aged 18–49 – from 29.2 per cent in NFHS-5 to 22.3 per cent – but the burden remains substantial: 24.4 per cent in rural India and 17.5 per cent in urban areas. The decline is encouraging; the legal contradiction remains. When legislative reform is repeatedly deferred, constitutional scrutiny cannot be indefinitely suspended. Where statutory distinctions implicate equality, dignity and bodily autonomy, judicial review must remain a safeguard against legislative inertia.

NCRB data reinforce another point. In 2024, 4.41 lakh crimes against women were registered, 1.5 per cent fewer than in 2023. Cruelty by husbands or their relatives remained the largest category, accounting for more than one in four registered cases. Yet marital rape does not appear as a distinct rape category because the law itself excludes it. Statistics cannot faithfully measure what the law refuses to name.

The courts have repeatedly exposed the discontent. In *Inde-*



The right to refuse intimacy cannot disappear after marriage

MARRIAGE CANNOT LOGICALLY TRANSFORM COERCION INTO CONSENT

pendent Thought v. Union of India (2017), the Supreme Court read down Exception 2 to Section 375 of the IPC insofar as it applied to wives below 18 years of age, harmonising the marital exception with the statutory age of consent and the framework of the POC SO Act. However, the judgment did not address the broader question of marital rape of adult women. The Delhi High Court's 2022 split verdict in *RIT Foundation v Union of India* produced no definitive resolution on the exception for adult wives. One judge found it unconstitutional; another upheld it. The issue stands unresolved.

Yet the Supreme Court has articulated a principle that sits uneasily beside the exception. In *X v Principal Secretary, Health and Family Welfare Department* (2022), while interpreting abortion law, the Court held that "rape" for the Medical Termination of Pregnancy framework includes sexual assault by a husband. It expressly observed that the nature of sexual violence and the contours of consent do not change upon marriage. Marriage cannot logically transform coercion into consent.

The objection to criminalisation is that it may destabilise marriage, encourage false complaints or expose husbands to arbitrary prosecution. These concerns deserve procedural answers, not immunity. The possibility of false complaints does not justify excluding a class of victims from protection. Nor is preserving a marriage a sufficient reason to deny a wife bodily autonomy. A marriage is a relationship of companionship, not a perpetual contract for sexual access.

Thus, Exception 2 to Section

63 should be removed, establishing a single standard of consent for married and unmarried adults. This need not mean abandoning safeguards. Prosecutions can be assessed on evidence rather than marital status.

But criminalisation cannot be the whole reform. The domestic-violence framework must remain available to survivors who need immediate protection rather than a criminal trial. Protection Officers need adequate staffing; shelters and legal aid must reach beyond major cities; hospitals need protocols for intimate-partner sexual violence; and police, prosecutors and judges require training. The objective should be to make it possible to say no without first leaving home, marriage or economic security.

India has accepted the principle that the home is not beyond the reach of law. It punishes domestic cruelty, dowry death and sexual violence against minors within families. The remaining question is whether an adult wife possesses the same legal right to refuse sexual activity as any other adult woman. The answer should not depend on marriage.

Consent is not a dowry surrendered at the altar, nor a promise that survives every subsequent refusal. It is present, freely given, and capable of withdrawal each time sexual intimacy occurs.

The real test of equality is found not in easy cases but in intimate ones. If the law recognises a woman's "no" everywhere except where she lives with her husband, then consent does not yet have equal value in India. The marital home cannot remain the jurisdiction in which a woman's refusal is legally diminished.

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

China's Xi Jinping to attend SCO summit in Kyrgyzstan

BEIJING: Chinese President Xi Jinping will attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit next week in the Kyrgyz capital Bishkek, which is expected to witness the participation of a host of world leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

President Xi will attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Bishkek as part of a state visit to Kyrgyzstan from August 30 to September 1, the Chinese Foreign Ministry announced on Wednesday.

Wildberries depot in Russia destroyed in Ukraine attack

KYIV: Long-range Ukrainian drones struck a major warehouse belonging to Russia's biggest online retailer, burning it to the ground, local authorities said Wednesday.

The depot in the Tambov region southeast of Moscow had been hit on July 18, killing seven people. That attack was the start of Ukraine's aerial campaign that has delivered repeated blows to Russian e-commerce giant Wildberries. The company's size and commercial importance brought comparisons with Amazon.

Trump believes Iran's supreme leader is still alive

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Wednesday said he believes that Iran's supreme leader Ayatollah Motajaba Khamenei is still alive.

Motajaba Khamenei was anointed supreme leader after his father, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, was killed in the opening moments of the US-Israel bombardment of Iran on Feb 28. The younger Khamenei was also badly wounded in the attacks and has remained out of public view. During an interview, Trump said he thinks Motajaba Khamenei is "very seriously wounded," but not dead.



Britain's Prime Minister Andy Burnham stacks loaves of bread onto a shelf with the help of Mayor of London Sadiq Khan

AP/PTI

Tanzania's vice Prez resigns

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Jerusalem, August 26

Tanzania's vice president is resigning after less than a year in office, following what analysts say was a power struggle with the country's first female leader.

Vice President Emmanuel Nchimbi offered to vacate the office on Sept. 4, according to a statement released on Tuesday. The presidency confirmed that constitutional measures will be taken to select a new deputy to President Samia Suluhu Hassan.

Nchimbi's statement said he was "fully convinced" that Hassan desires another deputy. "I assure you that I will continue to be a good citizen of Tanzania," it said.

His resignation is remarkable in a country known for its relative stability under the one-party rule of the Chama cha Mapinduzi party, or CCM.

Some analysts say he appeared to have disagreed with Hassan over governance and other issues stemming from the government's brutal crackdown on street protests during and after the Oct. 29 election.

WORLD BANK PLEDGES NRS 25 BILLION ASSISTANCE

Glacier collapse may have triggered deadly Nepal flash flood: Experts

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kathmandu, August 26

An ice-rock avalanche originating in a high-altitude area likely triggered the devastating flash floods that hurtled down from Tibet across central Nepal districts on Wednesday, experts at ICIMOD said.

Calling the disaster as an example of the increasing frequency of cryosphere hazards becoming more visible, the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) also underscored the need for early warning systems and stronger regional collaboration, with governments taking coordinated action to respond to cross-border hazards.

At least 95 people died and nearly 500, including 133 Indians, were missing after the torrential flash flood swept through



Rescuers use an earthmover to carry a victim of flash flooding to safety along the Trishuli River in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Wednesday

PTI

Bhote Koshi and Trishuli river systems.

The World Bank on Wednesday offered Nepalese Rs. 25 billion in emergency financial assistance to flood-hit Nepal for the rescue, relief and reconstruction of affected areas, according to the Ministry of Finance.

Scientists from the Kathmandu-headquartered ICIMOD and partner institutions in Nepal and China are investigating whether the flood may have been triggered by an ice-rock avalanche originating from a high-altitude area, a statement from the ICIMOD said.

Preliminary assessment based on video footage and information from affected areas suggest that a large volume of ice and rock debris may have entered the Lende Khola, a tributary of the Bhote Koshi river, the statement said.

China's Xi orders all-out rescue, relief efforts

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kathmandu, August 26

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Wednesday ordered all-out efforts to search for and rescue people missing after devastating flash floods swept through villages and towns near the China-Nepal border area in Tibet, causing heavy casualties.

A total of 145 officers and soldiers from the Xigaze detachment of the People's Armed Police have been sent to the affected border port to assist with emergency response operations.

A sudden, massive flood swept through two central Nepal districts bordering Tibet killing at least four people, causing extensive devastation at settlements along the river and damaging at least a dozen hydropower projects early Wednesday.

At least 105 Indians and 37 NRIs are among the nearly 400 persons missing.

Xi called for efforts to evacuate residents at risk



People move with their belongings at the flood affected Benighat area, in Dhading district on Wednesday

PTI

and provide timely medical treatment to the injured to minimise casualties.

He made the instructions after a mudslide occurred around 10:30 am on Wednesday, which caused severe casualties and left people unaccounted for at Gyirong border port in Gyirong County, the state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

Xi also stressed the need to strengthen monitoring and early warning, ensure scientific rescue operations and guard against secondary disasters.

Pak: 14 infants killed in fire at hospital

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Jerusalem, August 26

At least 14 infants were killed on Wednesday after a massive fire broke out in a gynaecology ward of a major hospital in Pakistan's capital Islamabad, authorities said.

The fire occurred around

multiple districts causing devastation in towns and villages, washing away bridges and damaging at least a dozen hydro-

power projects.

The flood surged through the Bhote Koshi River at around 9 am (local time) and the flood waters

then spread to several other districts. The flash floods sent a powerful surge of water, sediment and boulders through the

UNDER POTENTIAL DEAL WITH OMAN

Iran warns of military ship ban in Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Jerusalem, August 26

Iran will not allow military vessels to transit through the Strait of Hormuz under an agreement the Islamic Republic is currently negotiating with Oman, Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister told state TV late on Tues-

day night. The top diplomats of the two countries met to discuss managing commercial shipping traffic in the vital waterway, which remains largely shut down nearly six months after the Iran war began.

Meanwhile, Israel's strikes continued in Gaza, testing the already fragile

ceasefire with Hamas. Here's a look at the latest developments in the Iran war and the wider Middle East. Full coverage can be found here.

Iran and Oman have reached an understanding on a new framework for managing ship traffic in the Strait of Hormuz that would exclude military ves-

sels from traversing the vital waterway.

Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi told state TV late on Tuesday night that commercial shipping traffic into the Persian Gulf from the Gulf of Oman would pass entirely through Iranian waters.

CIA director held talks in Moscow with intel counterparts

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Moscow, August 26

The Kremlin said Wednesday that CIA Director John Ratcliffe held talks in Moscow with his intelligence counterparts, a rare and secretive visit at a time when relations with Washington remain strained over Russia's war in Ukraine.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Ratcliffe did not meet with Russian President Vladimir Putin.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No.:JHS/W/T/Tender General/193

Date : 24.08.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-C-2026-193, Description of work: Supply, stacking and mechanized loading of 150000 mt machine crushed track ballast as per Railway specification IRS-GE-I-June 2016 or latest at Khajraha depot, under ADEN/Lalitpur sub division.

Approx. Cost : ₹ 8,18,79,000.00

Earnest Money : ₹ 16,37,600.00

Date of closing Tender : 15.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 15 Months

(1) Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 15.09.2026 (2) For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in

1979/26 (MG)

North central railways

@CPRONCR

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice No.: JHS/Br/L/2026-27/09

Date: 22.08.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice (Single Packet System)

Dy. Chief Engineer/Bridge/Line/Jhansi, North Central Railway, Jhansi for and on behalf of President of India invites open E-Tenders on the prescribed forms for the under noted work:-

Tender No.: Br.-JHS-2026-09

Name of work: Provision of second Cover FOB (03 m wide) with standard ramp at Babina (BAB) station and ramps on existing FOB at Talbehat (TBT) station under DYCE/Br/Line/JHS

Approx.Cost of work (₹): ₹ 6,78,93,970.83

Bid Security (Earnest Money): ₹ 13,57,900.00

Completion Period: 12 Months

Date of Closing of Tender: 15.09.2026 (Up to 15:00 Hrs.)

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Fabrication and erection/launching of steel bridges/FOB.

Note:- (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on the due to date of tender closing i.e. 15.09.2026. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightway ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. (5) Payment of Bid Security (Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway or bank guarantee only. (6) In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. (7) Tender on line can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs. on dated 15.09.2026.

1978/26 (A)

North central railways

@CPRONCR

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No.: JHS/DYCM/2026/21

Date: 24.08.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of the President of India, The Dy Chief Material Manager, General Store Depot, Jhansi are invite the following E procurement tender.

S. N.

Tender No.

Description

Qty.

1

51256330A

SWITCH BOARD CABINET FOR LHB EOG AC COACHES as per Drg.No. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0184-2015 (Rev-02) of February 2026, Packing Instruction - P1115 VER 3.0.

30 Nos.

Tender Opening Date: 14.09.2026

EMD: ₹ 284180/-

Note: 1. The Complete information of above E-Procurement Tender are available on IREPS website i.e. <http://www.ireps.gov.in> 2. Bids other than in the form of E bids shall not be accepted against above tenders for this purpose venders are required to get themselves registered with IREPS Website along with class III digital signature certificate issued by CCA under IT act 2000. 3. Rules entered into financial rate page and duly signed digitally signature shall only be considered rates and any other financial entry in any other form/letter had if attached by vender shall be original straight way ignore and shall not be considered.

1980/26(AK)

North central railways

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www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA

Public Works Division Nanded

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Online Tender (e-tender) in B-1 form for the in Nanded District total 20 works are invited by the Executive Engineer, Public Works Division Nanded, Dist Nanded (Phone No.02462-253711) on Government of Maharashtra Electronic Tender Management System, from the registered contractor in appropriate class of Public works Department of Maharashtra State. The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Maharashtra e-tender portal <https://mahatenders.gov.in/> on sub portal www.mahapwd.gov.in as under.

Note: 1) Details of the tender documents are available on e-tendering <https://mahatenders.gov.in/> and www.mahapwd.gov.in website of the Government of Maharashtra.

2) If there are any changes in the tender notice, then the information will be display on the website.

3) Executive Engineer, Public Works Division Nanded, Dist Nanded has reserved the right to accept or reject tenders.

Executive Engineer

Public Works Division Nanded

Dgipr/2026-27/2507

e-PROCUREMENT NOTICE

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Sr. No.

Name of work

Estimated Cost

Starting date for download-ing Bid

EMD(Rs.

Deadline for Submission of Bid

1

R/R damages on Jabal Mann Bawasi Gamberpur road kmm. 0/0 to 8/500(SH--C/o R/wall at Rd 1/090 to 1/100

1,52,674/-

03.09.2026 From 10.30 AM

3,100/-

09.09.2026 at 18.00HRS

2

C/o Boxing Ring Shed at Degree College Arki Distt. Solan(HP)

1,44,760/-

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33,67,402/-

4

C/o Saryoni Dhert Aer Gater road km. 0/0 to 10/0(SH--Provid-ing and laying Premix Carpet in km. 5/565 to 8/575 & 9/0-25 to 9/625)Deposit

49,11,736/-

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Restoration of rain damages on Dadal Panipiplu road km. 0/0 to 9/0 (SH--Providing and Laying 25mm thick Bitumenious concrete in km. 8/0 to 9/0 and pot holes repair in km. 0/0 to 8/0

69,56,421/-

1,40,000/-

6

Restoration of rain damages on Shimla Kunihar Ramshear Nalagarh road portion km. 38/400 to 40/500(SH--Construction of retaining wall on both side of the road for 3.00 meter span RCC slab Cul-vert at RD 40/290

4,83,834/-

10,000/-

The Bidders are advised to note other details of tenders from the department website www.hptenders.gov.in.

Executive Engineer

HPPWD Division Arki, Distt. Solan H.P 173208

e.mail ee-ark-hp@nic.in

Ro.No 2918/2026-2027

HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK

For and on behalf of the Governor of H.P.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sannhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that that accused person Lalit S/o Madan @ Sunil R/o H. No. 411, Hotel Wali Gali, Kabir Basti, Malka Ganj, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence case FIR No. 240/2024 u/s 326/34 IPC & 25/27/54/59 Arms Act at P.S. Sabzi Mandi, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Lalit cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Lalit has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sannhita has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said Lalit accused of FIR No. 240/2024 u/s 326/34 IPC & 25/27/54/59 Arms Act at P.S. Sabzi Mandi, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 28.09.2026.

By Order: Ms. Preeti Rajoria,

Judicial Magistrate First Class-07,

Room No. 32, (Central)

Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/12011/N/2026

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Public Works Division Nanded

Dgipr/2026-27/2507

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Dgipr/2026-27/2507

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Dgipr/2026-27/2507

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1,40,000/-

6

Restoration of rain damages on Shimla Kunihar Ramshear Nalagarh road portion km. 38/400 to 40/500(SH--Construction of retaining wall on both side of the road for 3.00 meter span RCC slab Cul-vert at RD 40/290

4,83,834/-

10,000/-

The Bidders are advised to note other details of tenders from the department website www.hptenders.gov.in.

Executive Engineer

HPPWD Division Arki, Distt. Solan H.P 173208

e.mail ee-ark-hp@nic.in

Ro.No 2918/2026-2027

HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK

For and on behalf of the Governor of H.P.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha S

News at a glance

Govt mobilises about Rs 3K cr from Hindustan Copper OFS

NEW DELHI: S The government has realised nearly Rs 3,000 crore from share sale of Hindustan Copper with the closure of OFS on Wednesday. The offer for sale (OFS) for Hindustan Copper Ltd closed successfully with an enthusiastic response from retail investors, Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) Secretary Arunish Chawla said on X. The OFS comprised of 5.8 crore shares with base offer size 2,90,10,721 shares and oversubscription option of 2,90,10,721 shares.

Exports estimated at over \$25 bn during August 1-21

NEW DELHI: The country's merchandise export during August 1-21 is estimated to rise by 15 per cent to more than USD 25 billion, an official said on Wednesday. During April-August 21 this fiscal, the exports crossed USD 200 billion, the official said. India's exports increased by 19.63 per cent to USD 44.24 billion in July, even as the trade deficit widened to USD 31.98 billion. During April-July this fiscal, exports jumped 17.04 per cent to USD 173.78 billion, and imports climbed 19.27 per cent to USD 292.38 billion.

Bank of Baroda launches UPI Global Reverse Acceptance

MUMBAI: Bank of Baroda has launched UPI Global Reverse Acceptance, enabling international tourists, overseas Indians and foreign payment app users from eligible countries to make QR payments at its UPI merchants across India. The service supports cross-border merchant transactions through home-country banking or payment applications, covering corridors including Singapore, UAE, Nepal, Bhutan, Mauritius, Sri Lanka, US, Qatar and France. This eliminates need for visitors to carry cash or exchange currency.

India-Japan trade may reach \$50 bn by 2030: Assocham

NEW DELHI: India's bilateral trade with Japan is expected to reach USD 50 billion by 2030 on account of the growing economic complementarities and deeper business engagement between the two countries, industry body Assocham said on Wednesday. "India's trade relations with Japan are significantly expanding... Various bilateral trade developments and promising investment announcements are expected to enhance bilateral trade to USD 50 billion by 2030..." it said.

Briefs

Gold snaps 4-day rally

NEW DELHI: Gold prices declined by Rs 600 to Rs 1,66,500 per 10 grams in the national capital on Wednesday, snapping a four-day gaining streak amid weak trends in the international markets. However, silver rebounded modestly, rising Rs 500 to Rs 2,50,500 per kilogram from Tuesday's closing level of Rs 2.5 lakh per kg, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

Sugar prices rise again

NEW DELHI: Sugar prices rose for the second consecutive day on Wednesday, climbing over Re 1 per kg in the retail market amid increased festive demand, government data showed. The all-India average price rose to Rs 65.05 per kg from Rs 63.97 on Tuesday. Despite nearly 20 per cent decline in ex-mill rates following the government's decision to allow 10 lakh tonnes of raw sugar imports, retail prices remain elevated.

SBI launches CETA desk

LONDON: The State Bank of India (SBI), through its UK operations, has launched a dedicated India-UK CETA Facilitation Desk to help businesses capitalise on new opportunities created by the bilateral Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA). SBI UK said the desk, a joint initiative with SBI's London Branch, underscores India's leading financial institution's commitment to deepen trade and investment ties between the two economies.

FOCUS ON WIDER OPPORTUNITIES, BALANCED TRADE

Goyal says India & Japan to work on 'expanding scope' of trade pact

Ngoya, August 26

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Wednesday said he discussed reviewing the current trade pact with his Japanese counterpart, and both hope to work towards further expanding its scope.

The two countries implemented a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in August 2011.

The CEPA review is a long-pending demand of India to balance the bilateral trade.

Prime Ministers of both countries, during summit-level talks in New Delhi last month, announced that since it has been 15 years since the signing of CEPA, the two sides should discuss the pact and make it more contemporary.

"I have also discussed it with my counterpart minister, and we are hoping to work towards further expanding the scope and providing new opportunities for this relationship to grow," Goyal told



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal with Governor of Aichi Prefecture Hideaki Omura during a meeting, in Nagoya, Japan

CLOSER LOOK

- » The two countries implemented a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in August 2011
- » The CEPA review is a long-pending demand of India to balance the bilateral trade

reporters here.

Goyal is on a four-day official visit to Japan from August 24. He is leading a

large business delegation of over 200 representatives from different sectors. "We haven't got down

to work on terms of reference, but I think once the teams have discussed, we will be open to expanding the scope, scale and the extent of the engagement because Japan today is one of our most strategic partners," he added.

Both countries have big plans to strengthen the partnership, he said, adding that both sides have also discussed the importance of balanced trade.

The two-way commerce between the countries grew 9.18 per cent to USD 27.47 billion (exports of USD 6.03 billion and imports of USD 21.43 billion) in 2025-26 from USD 25.16 billion in 2024-25.

The trade deficit between the countries increased to USD 15.4 billion in the last fiscal year from USD 12.66 billion in 2024-25. It was USD 12.53 billion in 2023-24 and USD 11 billion in 2022-23.

However, he said that "we also have to see what kinds of goods we are importing...which are the things which we need, like equipment...which help

us in promoting economic activities".

The minister said he has asked different industries to submit challenges they are facing in exporting goods to Japan.

"Many times these challenges are more about process and language and time, and our mission stands ready to support all sectors," he said.

The commerce ministry is also supporting industry and exporters in registrations of their products to meet regulatory requirements, he noted. Under the export promotion mission scheme, the ministry will facilitate and support micro and small businesses in undertaking expensive registrations such as the European Union's REACH regulations for chemicals.

"For the pharma industry, I have also requested to start registrations all across the world...they should all look at registering all across the world, including Japan," he said.

Japan has announced to invest 10 trillion yen in India in one decade. PTI

REC net worth rises 9% to over Rs 84K cr

Disbursements hit record Rs 2.11L cr



MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 26

REC Limited, a Maharatna CPSE under the Ministry of Power, held its 57th Annual General Meeting on Tuesday, highlighting its record financial and operational performance during 2025-26 and growing role in India's energy transition. The AGM was held through video conferencing, providing shareholders an overview of the company's key achievements.

Addressing shareholders, REC Chairman and Managing Director Jitenendra Srivastava said the company maintained strong growth, resilience, sustainability and corporate governance amid a rapidly evolving global environment.

During FY26, REC recorded its highest-ever annual disbursements of Rs 2.11 lakh crore, while sanctions reached a record Rs 4.09 lakh crore. Its net worth crossed Rs 84,000 crore, registering around 9 per cent year-on-year growth, while gross loan assets stood at Rs 5.84 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026.

The company posted a net profit of Rs 16,282 crore and total income of Rs 59,187 crore during the financial year.

REC also expanded its renewable energy financing portfolio, sanctioning 58 projects with an aggregate installed capacity of more than 13,000 MW and loan assistance exceeding Rs 85,000 crore.

Its renewable energy loan assets crossed Rs 75,000 crore, registering around 30 per cent annual growth. Projects

'REC MAINTAINED STRONG GROWTH, RESILIENCE, SUSTAINABILITY & CORPORATE GOVERNANCE,' ITS CMD SAID AT AGM

financed by REC have cumulatively helped avoid approximately 7.6 million tonnes of carbon dioxide emissions.

During the AGM, Srivastava and the board unveiled the third edition of REC's Environmental, Social and Governance report, reflecting the company's focus on sustainable growth, responsible development and a cleaner energy ecosystem. REC received the highest rating in the National Stock Exchange's ESG ratings among 505 Indian companies. It also maintained ISO 31000:2018 and ISO 27001:2022 certifications for risk management and information security.

On social development, REC allocated Rs 338 crore under its CSR budget in FY26 for healthcare, rural development, environment, sports, armed forces support, infrastructure and community development.

Srivastava also said the proposed restructuring of REC and Power Finance Corporation, announced in the Union Budget 2026-27, was progressing.

The merger is expected to strengthen balance sheets, improve capital efficiency and create operational synergies, supporting large-scale funding and credit flow across the power sector.

Sensex falls nearly 183 points

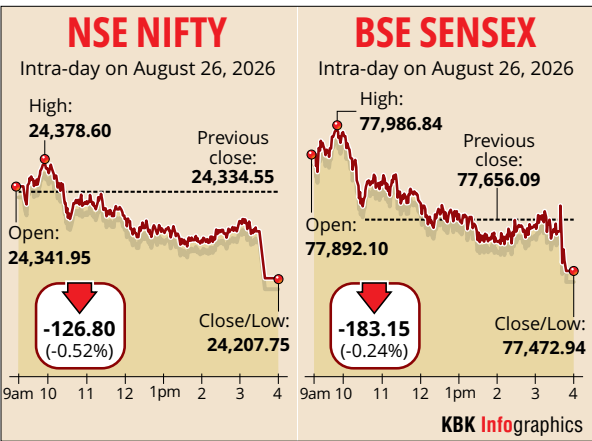
MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, August 26

Market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty drifted lower on Wednesday, giving up intraday gains, dragged by Reliance Industries and IT stocks.

The 30-share BSE Sensex settled at the intraday low of 77,472.94, down 183.15 points, or 0.24 per cent. During the session, the benchmark gained as much as 330.75 points to hit a high of 77,986.84.

The 50-share NSE Nifty was down 126.80 points, or 0.52 per cent, to end at 24,207.75.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Infosys, Bharti Airtel, Larsen & Toubro, Power Grid, Tech Mahindra, NTPC, Mahindra & Mahindra and Reliance



Industries were the major laggards. Kotak Mahindra Bank, UltraTech Cement, Axis Bank and Tata Steel were among the winners. Brent crude dropped 2.96 per cent to USD 85.96 per barrel.

The BSE SmallCap Select index was up 0.58

per cent and the MidCap Select index edged higher by 0.22 per cent. Among BSE sectoral indices, Telecommunication declined 1.35 per cent, IT 1.05 per cent, Focused IT 0.91 per cent, Utilities 0.65 per cent, Power 0.57 per cent and Realty 0.50 per cent.

Q1: NRI deposits drop 'over 23% to \$2.775 bn'

MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, August 26

Deposits by non-resident Indians (NRIs) declined over 23 per cent year-on-year to USD 2.775 billion during April-June 2026-27, according to the latest Reserve Bank of India data.

NRI deposits had recorded inflows of USD 3.614 billion in the April-June period of 2025-26.

Despite the moderation in fresh inflows, outstanding NRI deposits rose to USD 168.506 billion at end-June 2026 from USD 168.327 billion a year earlier, on the back of NRO and FCNR(B) deposits.

Inflows into Foreign Currency Non-Resident

(Bank) or FCNR(B) deposits more than doubled to USD 1.73 billion during April-June 2026-27, data showed. FCNR(B) deposits attracted USD 1.732 billion during the first quarter of 2026-27, compared with USD 774 million in the year-ago period, an increase of about 124 per cent.

The outstanding amount under FCNR(B) deposits rose to USD 35.487 billion at the end of June 2026 from USD 33.583 billion a year earlier.

On a month-on-month basis, outstanding FCNR(B) deposits increased from USD 34.038 billion at end-May 2026 to USD 35.487 billion at end-June 2026.

Adani Energy Solutions bags Rs 4,700 crore project in Maha

MPOST BUREAU
Ahmedabad, August 26

Adani Energy Solutions Ltd. (AESL) on Wednesday said it has secured a transmission project worth Rs 4,700 crore in Maharashtra for the evacuation of 4,500 MW of renewable energy and storage power.

The project "Network Expansion Scheme in Western Region to Cater to Pumped Storage Potential near Satara (up to 4500 MW) - Part A", was awarded to AESL through the Tariff Based Competi-

tive Bidding (TBCB) process, the company said in a statement.

AESL, a private transmission and distribution company and part of the globally diversified Adani portfolio, has won a key transmission project for the evacuation of renewable energy generated in Karnataka to major load centres in Maharashtra, according to the statement.

The project, which entails an estimated capital expenditure of Rs 4,700 crore, will also support the growing pumped storage

ecosystem in the Satara, Pune and Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), it said.

Housed under the Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) Satara Power Transmission Ltd., the project is scheduled to be completed within 36 months. It will add 562 circuit kilometres (ckm) of transmission lines and 9,000 MVA of transformation capacity to AESL's portfolio, taking its cumulative transmission network to 29,739 ckm and its transformation capacity to 1,43,425 MVA.

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 26

Domestic rating agency Crisil on Wednesday said the overall acquisitions by India Inc have doubled since FY17, but underlined that a third of them have not yielded desired outcomes.

The agency's managing director Subodh Rai said corporates opt for acquisitions due to a variety of reasons, including accelerating growth, expanding market access and acquir-

INSIGHT

- » The analysis spans 600 deals of over Rs 500 cr each across 20 sectors
- » Issues afflicting deals are topped by integration challenges

ing capabilities.

The deal volumes computed by the rating agency pointed out that the overall volumes have more than doubled since fiscal year

2017, he added.

The analysis spans 600 deals of over Rs 500 crore each across 20 sectors.

It excludes transactions in the financial services and infrastructure sectors and also inbound deals and ones led by private equity funds.

The agency said sectors like pharma and healthcare, enterprise technology, artificial intelligence and consumer businesses are using acquisitions to bridge technology, talent and intellectual-property

gaps. In the case of others like cement and metals, the motivations include consolidation, reducing build times from four-six years to one-three years.

Rai said the agency also assessed the deals from an outcome perspective. "Our review of 100 large debt-funded deals shows two in three deals broadly met our expectations," he said.

Issues afflicting deals are topped by integration challenges, the agency said, adding that other issues include regulatory

delays and cross-border execution issues.

"A sound strategic rationale alone is not enough to ensure M&A (mergers and acquisitions) success. Value creation depends on disciplined integration, timely synergy capture and prudent leverage management," it added.

Companies that executed integrations effectively were better positioned not only to realise benefits of acquisitions but also to manage and contain credit risk.

SHE WAS KNOWN FOR HER CURVY PHYSIQUE, MASSIVE BLOND WIGS AND SKIN-TIGHT OUTFITS THAT SERVED HER SELF-DEPRECATING WIT



RIP DOLLY PARTON

THE TRUE COUNTRY MUSIC QUEEN

Dolly Parton, the country music icon whose soaring vibrato vocals, poignant songwriting and sparkling costumes defined her rise from a log cabin in the Tennessee mountains to the height of stardom and acclaim, died in Nashville. She was 80 years old.

"After bravely facing a brief battle with cancer,

Dolly departed her earthly life today at the Vanderbilt-Ingram Cancer Center surrounded by loved ones," her publicist, Marcel Pariseau, said.

Known for her curvy physique, massive blond wigs and skin-tight outfits that served her self-deprecating wit, she was among the most beloved personalities in music and beyond - the rare celebrity whose appeal transcended generations, geography and politics.

She wrote hundreds of songs, including classics like 'Jolene', 'Coat of Many Colors' and 'I Will Always Love You', that totalled more than 100 million worldwide sales and more than one billion online streams. Parton, who plucked bejewelled banjos, guitar and dulcimers with her long fingernails during performances, was a generous philanthropist and successful businesswoman whose projects included a theme park in the Smoky Mountain foothills near her birthplace.

Her career was forever influenced by her upbringing as one of 12 children born into what she called a 'dirt poor' Tennessee family. She started her education non-profit, 'Imagination Library', to send free books to children in Tennessee because her father, who quit school to work on the farm, struggled to learn to read.

Parton's first musical performances were in church, where her grandfather was a preacher. By age 10, she was learning guitar and singing on local television shows. At 13, she appeared on the Grand Ole Opry in Nashville, where Johnny Cash introduced her as 'a little girl here from up in East Tennessee'.

With a suitcase of songs, she followed her uncle, Bill Owens, also



HER OTHER CROSSOVER HITS INCLUDED THE TITLE SONG FROM '9 TO 5', THE 1980 COMEDY STARRING PARTON, JANE FONDA AND LILY TOMLIN

a songwriter, to Nashville after graduating high school in 1964. Fred Foster, who produced Roy Orbison, Willie Nelson and more, saw her potential and got her songs cut by other artists, as well as recording and releasing Parton singing her own material. By the mid-1970s, Parton was a Nashville queen.

A key collaboration with Porter Wagoner

Parton's partnership with Porter Wagoner, a pencil-thin pompadoured star with flashy rhinestone outfits, was key to her career. She honed her acting skills on his syndicated TV show and he advocated for her to get a record deal at RCA. Their first duet, 'The Last Thing On My Mind', was released in 1967, the same year she started her own publishing company.

While their duets were often

big radio hits, Parton's solo singles didn't chart as high at first. With Wagoner as a co-producer, she began to adjust her country's warble to a more polished, pop-leaning style.

She got her first No. 1 solo single with 'Joshua' and reached the Top 5 with the ballad 'Coat of Many Colors', about how her mother sewed together scraps of clothes to make a coat Parton wore 'so proudly' even as her peers mocked her for being poor. The song, with its Biblical references and ode to maternal love, was later made into a children's book and a TV movie.

In 1973, she had the hit that made her career - 'Jolene', a country music standard with its steady, churning rhythm and Parton's repeated delivery of the title as she pleads for the woman not to steal her man.

The song topped the country charts, crossing over to pop and later being released internationally, opening up new audiences for Parton. 'Jolene' is one of her most covered compositions, including by Miley Cyrus (Parton's goddaughter), Olivia Newton-John and The White

Stripes. She left Wagoner's show in 1974, amid reports of squabbling between the two, although they continued to record together and Wagoner remained her producer for years after that. But the relationship turned litigious when Wagoner sued her in 1979 for millions in management fees and royalties.

A pop crossover star

She followed 'Jolene' with a huge hit in 1974, 'I Will Always Love You', an ode and farewell to Wagoner that helped her win the Country Music Association's female vocalist of the year back-to-back in 1975 and 1976. She famously turned down Elvis Presley, who wanted to record it, because she wouldn't share publishing rights. Decades later, Whitney Houston's version of 'I Will Always Love You' became a smash for the soundtrack of her 1992 film 'The Bodyguard' and broke sales records. Houston won a Grammy for her performance in 1994, presented to her by Parton.

'Here You Come Again', a pop crossover hit and one of the few she didn't write, further established Parton as a multi-genre entertainer and brought her first Grammy Award in 1979. "A lot of people thought I had totally lost my mind," she told 'The Associated Press' in 1979 of changing her singing style. "But I had no fear of change. I expected success, but I was braced for failure. I didn't care if people thought I was wrong. In my own heart, I knew I was doing the right thing."

Parton's other crossover hits included the title song from '9 to 5', the 1980 comedy starring Parton, Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin and her duet with longtime friend Kenny Rogers, 'Islands in the Stream', written by brothers Barry, Maurice and Robin Gibb of the Bee Gees. In 1987, she collaborated with Linda Ronstadt and Emmylou Harris on the million-selling 'Trio' album. AGENCIES

Shades of Chekhov's life

His stories 'Grief' and 'The Slanderer' were staged at the Muktaadhara Auditorium

RAJESH KUMAR
New Delhi, August 26

On Saturday, August 22, at 7 pm, Articol Theatre and Pictures presented stage adaptations of Anton Chekhov's stories, 'Grief' and 'The Slanderer', at the Muktaadhara Auditorium.

When adapting a story for the stage, directors often face a dilemma: whether to present it exactly as written or to take creative liberties and make it contemporary.

Janani Ray, the director of this production, adapted both stories in a way that, despite their Russian origins, evoked a sense of familiarity with the local setting. The audience felt the staged stories were

close to their own lives and surroundings. Hence, Janani Ray titled the production 'Zindagi' ('Life'). Both stories revealed different facets of life.

In the first piece, 'Grief', she played the lead role of a coachman, using her sensitive acting to realistically portray the empathy that is increasingly vanishing from modern society. The coachman (in this version, a woman) has lost her son and wishes to share her sorrow with her passengers, yet no one is willing to listen. Ultimately, alone at night, she pours out the story of her son's death to her horse. Janani Ray succeeded in conveying this anguish through her natural acting.



THE AUDIENCE FELT THE STAGED STORIES WERE CLOSE TO THEIR OWN LIVES AND SURROUNDINGS

Chekhov's second story, 'The Slanderer', was a satire on the segment of society that places more faith in falsehoods than in the truth. It depicted how people embellish and distort a minor incident from a party, ultimately shattering someone's personal life. Director Janani Ray presented this narrative with such wit and humour that the audience was left in fits of laughter.

The actors didn't merely entertain through their powerful performances - they also succeeded in exposing the hypocrisy prevalent in society.

The dozen actors who delivered outstanding performances in both plays were Kunal Gupta, Ajit Koli, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Anjali Marandi, Vijay Vastvik, Srishti Nair, Ritika Kumari, Sneha Charan and Minora Nair. Amit Bansal served as the production manager. There is no doubt that the event gloriously succeeded in bringing Chekhov's stories onto the stage, portraying the various facets of life.

Rajesh Kumar is an eminent playwright

Meet the chaotic gang of 'Don't Be Shy'!

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Mumbai, August 26

Alia Bhatt unveiled a brand-new poster, giving audiences another peek into the cool chemistry, youthful energy and effortless style of the gang headlining the upcoming 'Prime Original' movie, 'Don't Be Shy'!

Starring Aarushi Bajaj, Piyush Khatri, Bianca Arora



and Ansh Duggal, this coming-of-age romance promises a heart-felt, fun-filled celebration of friendship, love and the beautifully messy journey of growing up.

The film also stars Kunaal Roy Kapur, Anurag Basu, Neha Dhupia and Anju Alva Naik in pivotal roles.

JEWELLERY BRAND AD CONTROVERSY

Kriti's 'rakhi' ad pulled by GIVA

'GIVA' said its aim wasn't to 'hurt the sentiments of some segments of society'

Jewellery brand 'GIVA' said it has removed its Raksha Bandhan advertisement featuring Kriti Sanon, a day after it was heavily criticised on social media for the clothes the actress wore. In a statement posted on its social media pages, the brand said its aim was not to 'hurt the sentiments of some segments of society' and has withdrawn the ad.

"We have the highest regard and deep respect for Indian culture, traditions and festivals. As a brand, we have always believed in celebrating these joyous moments with the entire family and this time we wanted to extend love and celebration to our pets. If our recent advertisement has inadvertently hurt the sentiments of some segments of society, that was not our intent at all. Out of respect, we have withdrawn the said advertisement from all media. Wish you all the love & positivity this festive season!" 'GIVA' said.

In the ad, she was seen in an Indo-Western ensemble featuring a bralette-skirt combo with a cape and tying a rakhi to her brother and pet dog. The video led to an uproar with many criticising her choice of clothing during a traditional festival and some even objecting to her tying a Rakhi on a dog.

SHE WAS WEARING AN INDO-WESTERN ENSEMBLE FEATURING A BRALETTE-SKIRT COMBO WITH A CAPE AND TYING A RAKHI TO HER BROTHER AND PET DOG



CELEBRATING A MILESTONE



(From left) Sanjoo Malhotra, CEO, India Unlimited; Her Excellency Maria Malmer Stenergard, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Sweden and His Excellency Anurag Bhushan, Ambassador of India to Sweden, celebrated the 10th-anniversary milestone at 'Namaste Stockholm'

Briefs

Praggnan andhaa loses to Caruana

ST. LOUIS: Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa lost to pre-event favourite Fabiano Caruana of United States in the first game of the Grand Chess Tour grand finale here.

Praggnanandhaa was completely out of sort as Caruana outplayed him bit by bit from a complex Italian opening. Being Italian himself, Caruana probably knew a little more than the Indian and when the end-game arrived, he just had everything right clicking in favour.

Praggnanandhaa lost his case as his king was far away from defence and did not recover.

Pak to host South Asian Games

KARACHI: Pakistan will host the 14th edition of the South Asian Games from April 3 to 11 next year in Islamabad, Lahore and Peshawar after a delay of six years.

In a recent meeting held in Islamabad, South Asia Olympic Council (SAOC) approved the dates and venues of the multi-sporting event of the South Asian region.

The Games were initially to be held in 2021, but postponed several times due to various reasons, including the COVID-19 pandemic, before the proposed dates were pushed back by a month again from March to April next year.

DESPITE SOORIYABANDARA, MENDIS FIGHT India on verge of series win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Colombo, August 26

Sri Lankan batters were defiant in phases but the Indian bowlers made a timely intervention to reduce the hosts to 229 for six in their second innings on day four of the second and final Test here on Wednesday.

Sonal Dinusha (7) and Keshara Nuwantha (3) were in the middle at stumps when the now customary evening rain and bad light stopped play.

But India will be eager to end Lanka's last vestige of hope and wrap the match and series on day five. Before Indian bowlers established their domination, the 115-run third wicket alliance between Pasindu Sooriyabandara (92) and Kamindu Mendis (55) was the primary source of Lankan fightback.

Sooriyabandara and Mendis joined forces when Lanka were wobbling at 63 for two, but resisted the Indian bowlers for the next 110 minutes.

The pair bridged the heavy 213-run innings deficit that forced them to follow-on. However, Sri Lanka's effort in that period was a marked



Manav Suthar celebrates with teammates after taking the wicket of Sri Lanka's captain Dhananjay de Silva on the fourth day of the second Test against Sri Lanka, in Colombo on Wednesday

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Sooriyabandara and Mendis joined forces when Lanka were wobbling at 63 for two, but resisted the Indian bowlers for the next 110 minutes
- » The pair bridged the heavy 213-run innings deficit that forced them to follow-on

improvement from their first dig in which they were bundled out for 290, which was a mere 13 runs shy of the follow-on mark.

That total was constructed around the highly-impressive Dinusha's 103,

Starc replaces Bumrah as top-ranked Test bowler

SL bowlers Asitha Fernando, Prabath Jayasuriya have both moved up five places to 15th, 16th

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai, August 26

Australia fast bowler Mitchell Starc has attained the No. 1 position in the ICC Test rankings for the first time in his career after his 10-wicket haul in MacKay helped win the second match of their ICC World Test Championship series against Bangladesh.

The 36-year-old left-arm grabbed six for 12

and four for 39 to star in the innings and 51 runs victory, overtaking Matt Henry and Jasprit Bumrah, whom he leads by 10 rating points.

Starc, whose previous best position was second that he first achieved after the Boxing Day Test last year, was named the Player of the Match and the Player of the Series.

Bumrah's latest reign at the top lasted just two

months but he has a combined 697 days as number one, which is the most by an India bowler and the 14th-most ever.

England seam bowler Ollie Robinson is another major gainer, his hauls of five for 51 and three for 39 helping him win the Player of the Match award in an innings and 103 runs victory over Pakistan in the first of three Tests in Leeds and lifted him 15 spots to

11th among bowlers.

Josh Tongue, who also grabbed eight wickets at Headingley, has progressed 16 places to 17th. India's left-arm spinner Manav Suthar has risen 28 places to a career-best 48th after taking 10 wickets in India's 165-run win over Sri Lanka in the first Test in Galle.

Sri Lanka bowlers Asitha Fernando and Prabath Jayasuriya have both

Hockey: India eye 5th place finish against higher ranked Germany

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Colombo, August 26

India will look to put the disappointment of missing out on a semifinal spot behind them and sign off from the Women's Hockey World Cup with a win when they face higher-ranked Germany in the fifth-place playoff here on Wednesday.

For India, the contest is not just about finishing fifth but also about carrying the confidence of an impressive World Cup campaign into next month's Asian Games, where a gold medal would bring direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

India have lost just one match in the tournament and, irrespective of the result against the two-time champions, are assured of their best World Cup finish since their fourth-place effort in the inaugural edition in 1974.

India, featuring 11 World Cup debutants, will face a stern test against a side that has already beaten it twice in practice matches before the tournament.

India's semifinal hopes were dashed on Sunday after a goalless draw against Australia in their



Salima Tete celebrates after scoring a goal during the Women's Asian Champions Trophy 2023 match against China in Ranchi

INDIA, FEATURING 11 WORLD CUP DEBUTANTS, WILL FACE A STERN TEST AGAINST A SIDE THAT HAS ALREADY BEATEN IT TWICE IN PRACTICE MATCHES BEFORE THE TOURNAMENT

final second-round pool match, where they needed a win to progress.

The three-day break, however, has given Sjoerd Marijne's side time to recover from the disappointment and refocus on

the final challenge.

"This rest was crucial to recover from the setback in the previous match. Now, the team will play against Germany with renewed vigour and freshness," Marijne said. "The team has overcome the disappointment of not reaching the semifinals and is now fully focused on defeating Germany and leaving the tournament with a win. We want to improve our game and perform better for the Asian Games."

India began their campaign with a 2-2 draw against Olympic silver medallists China before thrashing South Africa 6-1, with six different players finding the net.

Chess: Praggnanandhaa loses to Caruana

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
St. Louis, August 26

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa lost to pre-event favourite Fabiano Caruana of United States in the first game of the Grand Chess Tour grand finale here.

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Being Italian himself,

Caruana probably knew a little more than the Indian and when the endgame arrived, he just had everything right clicking in favour.

Praggnanandhaa lost his case as his king was far away from defence and did not recover. With Classical victory worth six points, it's a huge lead for Caruana already and it remains to be seen if Praggnanandhaa can match up to the American who ranks number three in the world currently.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No:-DRM-CI/AGRA/NFR/E-AUCTION Date: 25.08.2026

E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per category given as under:-

Category: Misc-Static-Services Catalogue No.: NFR-AGRA-26-11

Asset Details

Tender for the Operation and Maintenance of the "Virtual Brand Promotional Kiosk" at Mathura Jn. Railway Station.

E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date:- 09.09.2026 Time:- 11:00

E-Auction End Date and Time : Date:- 09.09.2026 Time:- 11:30

Tender for the Operation and Maintenance of the "Virtual Brand Promotional Kiosk" at Agra Cantt. Railway Station.

E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date:- 09.09.2026 Time:- 11:10

E-Auction End Date and Time : Date:- 09.09.2026 Time:- 11:40

Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1987/26 (MG)

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No. 26/40 Dt: 25.08.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of the President of India, The Principal Chief Materials Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj, (An ISO 9001:2015 Certified unit) invites the following E-Procurement Tenders.

S. N.	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Tender Opening Date
1	20263251	Intermediate Overhauling Kit (IOH Kit) for Single Bottle VCB	72 Set.	23.09.2026
2	20263764	Repair kit for EP Relay valve	119 Set.	24.09.2026
3	2026374A	Secondary spring for WAG9/WAP7 locos	89 Nos.	28.09.2026
4	20263658A	Zirconium Copper Stamping	1842 Nos.	30.09.2026
5	20263757	Set of items for "H" type tight lock coupler	43 Set.	05.10.2026
6	20263588	Kit for E-70 Brake Control Unit	27 Set.	06.10.2026
7	RGC240FC5026	24 Fibre Armoured Optical Fibre Cable	638 KM	16.09.2026
8	RGC12CORE5026	12 Core signaling cable	3539 KM	14.09.2026
9	70264194	Pillow Cover, Size 50x36 CM	229403 Nos.	06.10.2026
10	70254301C	Winter Jacket	5496 Nos.	12.11.2026
11	70261591	Rolling Flat Segment	23 Set	29.10.2026
12	70261592	Roller taper segment W 5.4	23 Set	27.10.2026

Note : • The complete information of above tenders can be seen and downloaded from IREPS website i.e. <https://www.ireps.gov.in>. • For any change/corrigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No separate corrigendum/change will be published in news paper. 1973/26 (AS)

North central railways @www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Office of Chief Track Engineer

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Chief Track Engineer, North Central Railway, Prayagraj for and on behalf of the President of India invites open online e-Tender (Two Packets System) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: NCR-TP-GPR-2026-01. Approx Cost: Rs. 26.91 Crore

Description of work: Monitoring health of ballast bed with the help of ground penetration radar technology for through ballast renewal (TBR) and formation rehabilitation on Indian Railways.

Date of closing Tender: 30.10.2026

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 36 Months

Tender on line can be submitted upto 15.00 hrs. on 30.10.2026. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. 1977/26(K)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS!

MORE RAKSHA BANDHAN SPECIAL TRAINS

In order to clear extra rush of passengers on the occasion of Raksha Bandhan, Railway have decided to run the following Special Trains as per schedule given below:-

Train No.:	04415	↓	STATIONS	↑	Train No.:	04416
ARR.	DEP.				ARR.	DEP.
----	19:10		Delhi Sarai Rohilla		06:30	----
00:40	----		Ringas Jn.		----	02:00

DATE OF RUN: 04415 Ex Delhi Sarai Rohilla on 27.08.2026 & 28.08.2026 and 04416 Ex Ringas Jn. on 28.08.2026 & 29.08.2026.

STOPPAGES: Delhi Cantt., Gurgaon, Pataudi Road, Rewari Jn., Narnaul & Nim Ka Thana stations.

ACCOMMODATION: General Class.

Train No.:	04012	↓	STATIONS	↑	Train No.:	04011
ARR.	DEP.				ARR.	DEP.
----	21:10		Delhi Jn.		10:20	----
11:45	----		Varanasi Jn.		----	19:50

DATE OF RUN: 04011 Ex Delhi Jn. on 27.08.2026 and 04011 Ex Varanasi Jn. on 28.08.2026.

STOPPAGES: New Delhi, Ghaziabad, Hapur, Moradabad Jn., Rampur, Bareilly Jn., Shahjahanpur, HarDOI, Lucknow Jn., Sultanpur Jn. & Jaunpur City stations.

ACCOMMODATION: 1st AC, AC-2 Tier, AC-3 Tier, Sleeper & General Class.

Train No.:	04546	↓	STATIONS	↑	Train No.:	04545
ARR.	DEP.				ARR.	DEP.
----	19:40		Chandigarh Jn.		02:10	----
09:30	----		Lucknow Jn.		----	13:00

DATE OF RUN: 04546 Ex Chandigarh Jn. on 27.08.2026 and 04545 Ex Lucknow Jn. on 28.08.2026.

STOPPAGES: Ambala Cantt., Barara, Jagadhri Workshop, Yamunanagar Jagadhri, Saharanpur Jn., Moradabad Jn., Bareilly Jn., Shahjahanpur Jn. & HarDOI stations.

ACCOMMODATION: AC-2 Tier, AC-3 Tier, Sleeper & General Class.

For detailed information regarding stoppages and timings of above train, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit enquiry website: www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in or NTES App.

RailMadad Helpline No. 139 Visit RailMadad website:- www.railmadad.indianrailways.gov.in Download RailMadad app.

Please join us on **NORTHERN RAILWAY** Always at your service Visit us at : www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 2957/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PSPCL Punjab State Power Corporation Limited

Regd. Office: (PSEB, Head Office, The Mall, Patiala-147001.) Corporate Identification Number U40109PB20105GCG033813 Website www.pspcl.in (Contact No. 96461-01116)

Tender Enquiry No. 36/GCD/LDH/TS/PSPCL/2026 Dated:-27.08.2026

ASE/ Grid Construction, opp. PAU Gate No.1, PSPCL, Ludhiana invites Short Term e-Tender for Outsourcing of 1 no. New 66 KV Substation Bhamipura with 20 MVA PTF works on partial turnkey mode under Grid Construction Division, Ludhiana under Grid Construction Circle, Ludhiana.

For detailed NIT & Tender Specifications please refer to <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 27.08.2026 (01:00 PM onwards).

Note:- Corrigendum & amendments, if any, will be published online at <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in>.

C-825/26 PR-Advt. No :- 1079/12/2026-27/14608

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. : 7120262027 Dated : 24.08.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 13:30 hrs. on 15.09.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:

Tender No. : 154 [Approx. Cost of Work (Rs.) : 78,26,037.05]

Name of work: Construction of Gang Rest Sheds at various locations in CNB-RRH section under DENM/PRYJ.

Earnest money (Rs.) : 1,56,500.00 [Completion Period : 06 Months]

Date of Opening of tender : 16.09.2026

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria : Any Civil Engineering work

Note : 1. Tender on line can be submitted upto to 13:30 hrs. on 15.09.2026 2. The complete information along with tender documents of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 16.09.2026 1974/26 (C)

North central railways @www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. 7020262027 Dated: 24.08.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 13:30 hrs. on 15.09.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:

Tender No. : 153 [Approx Cost of Work (Rs.): 39748845.33]

Name of work: Flash butt welding of rails on loop lines and other lines under Sr. DEN/III/PRYJ.

Bid security (Rs.): 795000.00 [Completion Period: 12 Months]

Date of Opening of tender: 15.09.2026

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any P. Way work involving weld renewal work with mobile flash butt welding plant.

Note:- 1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders is available on website www.ireps.gov.in up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 15.09.2026. The tender shall be opened at or after 15:00 hrs. on due date of opening. 2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. 4) Tender No. 153 is having advertised value more than 50 Lakhs, therefore, Annexure-V & V(A) (Document Verification Certificate) is required. The supplier/contractor of goods and/or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. 5) This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. 6) In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 7) Tender online can be submitted upto to 13:30 hrs. on 15.09.2026. 8) E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. 9) For tender no. 153: The tenderers have to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of IRGCC-2022 (Works matter) mandatorily, otherwise their offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 1969/26(K)

North central railways @www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender No.: PU-AGC-ST-MSDAC-T01A-2026 Dated: 25.08.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Dy. Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer/Proj, Agra Cantt, North Central Railway for and on behalf of the President of India invites open e-Tender from reputed contractors/JV firms with adequate experience and financial capability, for the following work on Two Packet System up to 15.00 hrs. on the opening date of E-tender mentioned therein. If date of opening is declared a holiday or offer could not be opened due to technical issue, the offers shall be opened on the next working day. The details of the Tender are as under:

Name of work: Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of MSDAC, Alteration/Modification in Electronic Interlocking and associated works in connection with Provision of dual detection at vulnerable location of Mathura Junction Station of Agra Division of North Central Railway.

Estimated cost of work: Approx. Cost Rs.: 139332918.85 only (Thirteen Crore Ninety-Three Lakh Thirty-Two Thousand Nine Hundred Eighteen Rupees and Eighty-Five Paise Only)

Bid Security: Rs. 2786700.00 Tender form cost: NIL

Completion Period: 12 Months. Availability of tender form: Tender forms shall be available on website. www.ireps.gov.in. 21 days (minimum) prior to date of opening of the tender.

Closing Date / Time of Tender : 15.09.2026 before 15:00 Hrs.

Tender Opening Date / Time : 15.09.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.

Place of Opening: Through Online E-Portal www.ireps.gov.in in the office of Dy. CSTE/Proj/AGC, Divisional Railway Office, Agra Cantt (UP) - 282001

Validity of Offer: 90 days from date of opening.

Right of Railway to deal with tender: Railway administration reserves the rights to postpone/modify or to cancel the tender without assigning any reasons.

Tenderers who wish to participate in tenders invited on www.ireps.gov.in have to register on the website mandatorily. Please refer to website for more details. Tenderers can submit EMD only through online mode. Online payment of Bid security can be made through net banking, debit/credit card etc. Further particulars can be obtained from Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 1976/26 (PH)

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE No. L-Open-26-27-12, Dt.24.08.2026

The Divl. Rly. Manager (Elect/G)/Sonpur for and on behalf of the President of India invites "Open E-Tender" for following works. The last date of online E-tendering is 18.09.2026 upto 12.30 Hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website-www.ireps.gov.in.

Sl. No. 1 Name of work : At Hajipur :- Provision of facade lighting at GM building Hajipur. Approx Cost (in Rs.): 92,10,985.37. Earnest Money (in Rs.): 1,84,200.00. Cost of Tender document (in Rs.) (Non-refundable): 00.00.

The above Tender notice is available on Website- www.ireps.gov.in. RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER: Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone / modify or to cancel the tenders without assigning any reason.

Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/(Elect/G) East Central Railway, Sonpur PR/0798/SEE/ENGG/T/26-27/32

OUTSOURCING FOR MAINTENANCE OF TL/AC COACHES

E-Tender No. EL-GHY-KYO-03-26-27-RT Dated: 14-08-2026. Works tenders through "E" Tendering system for and on behalf of the President of India are invited for the works as detailed below: Name of work: Outsourcing of non-core activities for the maintenance of TL/ AC (Conventional + LHB) coaches at Guwahati, New Guwahati & Kamakhya coaching depots alongwith staff for passing train attention for a period of 02 years. Tender Value: ₹8,71,65,282/-. Earnest Money: ₹5,85,800/-. Date & time of closing of tender: At 12.00 hrs. on 05-09-2026. The complete information with tender documents of above e-tender will be available in the website www.ireps.gov.in

Sr.DEEE Coaching/Guwahati & Kamakhya

NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY Serving Customers With A Smile



AROUND THE WORLD

- » President Murmu to meet students and teachers on Raksha Bandhan
- » Bihar launches 24×7 'Vidya Saathi' teacher support for Classes 9-12, JEE-NEET prep
- » UP government doubles MBBS, BDS interns' stipend to Rs 25,000
- » BITS Pilani Goa campus researchers develop pharmaceutical polymer-based bioink for 3D-printed skin scaffolds and customized drug delivery



BUZZER ROUND

Q1 Who was the first Indian actor to get a star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our Aug 20 edition question: **Gulzarilal Nanda**

Correct answers were sent by: **Monodeep Mitra, Abhishek Dutta, Sohini Majumdar**



NEWS & VIEWS

US visa applicants, particularly Indians, are facing growing uncertainty as consulates pause or reschedule appointments amid fresh training, while changes to H-1B rules, stricter screening and proposed F-1 reforms could further affect study, employment and relocation plans.

Around 200 students of a government school in Chhattisgarh's Durg district took to the streets, blocking a main road to protest the lack of proper toilets and a boundary wall. The demonstration was called off after the tehsildar assured them that toilet facilities would be constructed, but the students said they would wait for actual work to begin before considering the matter resolved.

SCHOLARSHIP



NETFLIX ANNOUNCES SCHOLARSHIP FOR 100 STUDENTS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The Indian Institute of Creative Technologies (IICT), in collaboration with Netflix, has announced scholarships for 100 students, providing financial assistance of up to 80 per cent for six professional programmes. The initiative covers two one-year diploma courses and four six-month certificate programmes.

The scholarship programmes include a Diploma in Interactive Comics and Sequential Arts, Diploma in Visual Effects Mastery, Certificate in Virtual Art Department Content Creation, Certificate in Media Tech Workflow, Certificate in Art of Character Animation, and Certificate in E-Sports & Gaming Management.

According to the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, the partnership is aimed at nurturing India's creative talent pool and strengthening the country's emerging 'Orange Economy'.

The announcement comes shortly after Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Netflix Co-CEO Ted Sarandos on August 5. During the meeting, Modi underlined India's strong storytelling heritage and vast creative talent base, noting that these strengths could be harnessed to establish the country as a leading global hub for content creation.

Selected candidates will be invited for a personal interview with the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies faculty and an Indian Institute of Creative Technologies-Netflix Scholarship Panel member, based on approved evaluation criteria. The applications are till September 30. Scholarship coverage ranges from 50% to 80% of the applicable programme fee.

INDIA & FRANCE TO STRENGTHEN AVGC-XR TALENT WITH DESIBEL



OUR CORRESPONDENT

If you are interested in animation, visual effects or gaming, then you are surely going to love this initiative. India and France are strengthening their partnership with the introduction of 'Desibel', a multi-year initiative focused on building next-generation skills and global connections in India's AVGC-XR (Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming, and Comics and Immersive Content) sector. Backed by a two-year-grand, this initiative of Embassy of France in India and the French Institute in India (IFI), with support from the French Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, brings together four of India's leading cultural organisations, spanning community libraries, publishing, and the animation and XR industry, reflecting the diversity and depth of India's visual storytelling ecosystem.

Thierry Mathou, Ambassador of France to India, said, "France has emerged as a pioneering partner in building cooperation with India in the AVGC-XR industry. The strategic importance of this collaboration was underscored by the recognition of the Desibel initiative during President Emmanuel Macron's visit to India last February, which opened the India-France Year of Innovation 2026." The French organisers have united three Indian partners, Kutumb Foundation, Westland Books, and Aniverse & Visual Arts Foundation to drive impact from grassroots communities to the global stage.

IS AI CLOSING THE DOOR ON ENTRY-LEVEL JOBS?

AI is compressing routine work, forcing young professionals to rethink how they build skills and careers

ANINDITA ACHARYA

A few years ago, ad agencies routinely hired junior copywriters to write standard product descriptions, meta tags and email copy. Call centres were once a popular entry point into the workforce. Even data entry executives were once highly valued across organisations. Today, however, data entry is among the jobs most vulnerable to AI automation, with more than 7.5 million such jobs expected to be eliminated by 2027.

The rise of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and its rapid adoption across sectors is fundamentally changing the structure of work. According to the World Economic Forum, more than one in three young workers globally (37%) are employed in occupations with medium-to-high exposure to AI-driven task change. At the same time, junior-level job postings fell 7% year-over-year in 2025, while senior-level postings rose 4%, according to a career-hunting portal.

Gen Z has become a buzzword in India, whether in politics, entertainment, education or the job market. Yet it is this generation that is increasingly finding itself at the centre of the AI-driven transformation of work. A new Stanford study found that employment among workers aged 22 to 25 in highly AI-exposed occupations declined by about 11% between November 2022 and June 2026, while employment among the same age group in less AI-exposed jobs grew by roughly 10%. The findings raise an important question: is this a warning sign for young people entering the workforce? Shantanu Rooj, Founder and CEO, TeamLease Edtech, doesn't mince words when he said that early-career roles are certainly among the most exposed to AI-led task change, but exposure should not be confused with job elimination. "The World Economic Forum estimates that 37% of young workers globally are employed in occu-



COMPANIES NEED TO AVOID A SITUATION WHERE AI IMPROVES SHORT-TERM PRODUCTIVITY BUT INADVERTENTLY REMOVES THE FIRST RUNG OF THE CAREER LADDER

pations with medium-to-high exposure to AI-driven task change, largely because junior roles traditionally contain a higher proportion of routine tasks such as research, documentation, data processing, basic coding and customer support. However, the ILO finds that one in four workers globally is in an occupation with some GenAI exposure, while only 3.3% of global employment falls into its highest-exposure category, and concludes that transformation is more likely than wholesale replacement," he said. In fact, Rooj cited TeamLease EdTech's Career Outlook Report HY2 2026 where they observed that despite rapid AI adoption, 75% of employers intend to hire freshers during July-December 2026, with AI Application Developer itself among the leading entry-level roles.

According to Pravesh Dudani, Founder & Chancellor, Medhavi Skills University, AI is not eliminating careers; it is eliminating the conventional way of entering them. "The real danger is not that AI takes away every entry-level job, but that we lose the learning opportunities embedded within those jobs. The answer cannot be to protect outdated roles. We need to redesign such roles by combining AI with apprenticeship, mentorship, problem-solving and real-world exposure," he said. The disruption is not limited to a particular industry or geography. In an NDTV interview, IMF chief Kristalina Georgieva said

that an estimated 40 per cent of the global workforce - entry-level jobs in particular - will be impacted by AI and AI-based technological disruptions.

For young job seekers, therefore, the challenge is not simply to acquire AI skills but to develop capabilities that complement technology. Dr Mary N Odyuo, Associate Professor, Department of Agricultural Extension Education, Nagaland University, believes that young job seekers should learn how to use AI as a tool, while also developing communication, critical thinking, creativity, problem solving and adaptability. "AI skills alone are not enough. They need to know how to use technology while bringing skills that AI cannot easily replace like good communication and empathy," he said.

The debate over AI and jobs has also prompted warnings from some of the world's leading technology voices. In a recent interview to 'The New York Times', Microsoft co-founder Bill Gates warned that AI could cause unprecedented disruption to jobs and pose serious risks to human life. Swapnil Sahoo, Great Lakes Institute of Management, Gurgaon, is



BLACKBOARD

IT Guwahati researchers have developed a water-treatment technology that can remove arsenic and fluoride simultaneously from contaminated groundwater. This could be a vital contribution towards ensuring safer and affordable drinking water in regions affected by naturally-occurring groundwater pollution.

Indian job postings on a job-hunting portal rose 1.2% in July 2026, following three consecutive months of decline to stand 8.3% higher than a year ago. While postings have been volatile recently, hiring intensity across India remains elevated, with postings still 8.4% above pre-pandemic levels, a survey said.

Hansraj College, University of Delhi, has taken a significant step towards strengthening global academic and research collaborations with the University of Chicago in the emerging field of Radiopharmaceutical Chemistry. The proposed scientific partnership focuses on the development of next-generation PET tracers for mapping biochemical pathways, with promising implications for molecular imaging, radiopharmaceutical chemistry, and biomedical sciences.

A CENTURY ON AIR

SNU CELEBRATES AKASHVANI KOLKATA'S RICH LEGACY

OUR CORRESPONDENT

On Wednesday, Sister Nivedita University (SNU), Kolkata, celebrated 100 years of Akashvani Kolkata through an endearing programme steeped in nostalgia, creativity and love for the radio.

Techno India Group Managing Director and SNU Chancellor Satyam Roychowdhury stirred a nostalgia when he talked about how Akashvani Kolkata influenced his life. He remembered how simply through the richness of their voice, the radio jockeys, then called radio announcers, made his leisure time entertaining and meaning-

ful. He also recited Rabindranath Tagore's 'Bharat Tirtha'. Also, present on the occasion were former ADG, AIR, Pradip Kr Mitra, RJ Mahua, eloquentist Biplab Ganguly. They enriched the afternoon with their rich tapestry of experience which they shared with an enthralled audience.

Dr Dhrubajyoti Chattopadhyay, Pro-Chancellor, TIG Universities & Central Academic Leader, Techno India Group, talked about the history of Akashvani Kolkata, which is also known as All India Radio (AIR) and how it began its service on August 26, 1927, completing 100 years on Wednesday. He also became nostalgic remembering how



radio was a part of his growing up years.

Vice Chancellor, SNU, Dr Anupam Basu also became nostalgic while talking about

Akashvani Kolkata. He set the tone of the day by sharing his personal anecdotes. The day also saw two audio dramas being played out. Dr Arumoy

Banerjee and Swati Banerjee enacted Soumendu Ghosh's 'Charai Pakhi Sakshi', to the enjoyment of the gathering. Based on Manoj Mitra's 'Lot-

tery Pabar Pore', the second play adopted and directed as 'Surjodipa' by Arindam Basu, was enacted by Saikat Majumdar and Jhumur Dutta Gupta and received a loud round of applause from the audience. COO SNU Abhijit Mukher-

SNU CHANCELLOR SATYAM ROYCHOWDHURY STIRRED A NOSTALGIA WHEN HE TALKED ABOUT HOW AKASHVANI KOLKATA INFLUENCED HIS LIFE

jee gave an audio-visual presentation of Akashvani, highlighting its various milestones, through plays and programmes from the greats like Birendra Krishna Bhadra, Uttam Kumar, Ajitesh Bandopadhyay, Sambhu Mitra, among others.

The programme was organised by the Journalism and Mass Communication Department of the university. Dean School of Journalism and Mass Communication Dr Minal Pareek said, "It is our way to pay tribute to the radio station that has been an integral part of Bengal's cultural mainstream. It is also an effort to let Gen Z understand the importance of Akashvani."